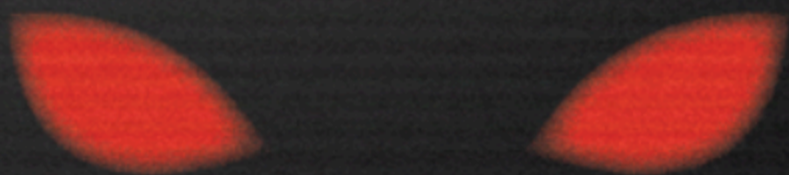


GATHERING
AGAINST
SUPERNATURAL
PHENOMENA



I want to stand for something good

I want to do something good

I want to be something that is good.

1.

Earlier on the day that Samuel Broley died, Ken was not with his family. Instead, he was set to attend a meeting of the heroes. It was a critical appointment, he told them.

Josephine, Ken's nephew, and her parents stared down at Hope City from a lookout on top of one of the tallest buildings in the city. While they were there to sightsee the city, and they could see much of it, Jo found herself enamored with the superheroes flying into the city from across the world. Their colorful capes rippled through the air just barely perceivable from where they watched.

"Mommy, you think Uncle Ken is flying in?" she asked.

"No, he doesn't fly on his broom, Honey," her mother said.

Jo's father took pictures of Jo staring out at the city. This trip had been his idea after all. The family always dreamed of seeing Hope City. It was everyone's dream to feel the energy in it. It was the place where people could do more. Millions of people stacked onto one another, each vying to make their mark on the city. Considering his brother-in-law was going to be in town too, it seemed to be the opportune time to visit. Jo dashed from glass wall to glass wall watching the cars pass by down below.

Once the heroes had settled into town, thereby clearing the air, they went down a few levels in the skyscraper to get lunch. Jo's family sat in an expensive restaurant with white table clothes and large windows overlooking Hope City.

“You think their burgers are good?” Jo’s father asked her mother.

“I’d imagine they are acceptable. It isn’t exactly what they specialize in though,” she said. Her father stroked his beard before letting loose a sigh.

“When is Uncle Ken going to wrap up his meeting?” Jo asked.

Her father looked up from his menu. His glasses were sitting on top of his head. “We don’t know. Whenever they talk about everything they need to.”

“Don’t worry. We’ll see him for dinner,” her mother said.

What happened next was always a little hard to remember. Maybe it was because she didn’t understand it at the time. Maybe it was because it had been so long. After their parents ordered their food, her mother’s phone rang.

She picked it up and said, “Hey, Ken! How is your—I understand . . . Oh . . . Okay. We’re on it.” Her mother flipped the phone closed and stood up. “We need to get out of here now.” Her father, having heard the conversation over the phone, was already standing.

“What’s happening, Mom?” Jo asked.

Her mother looked to her father, took a deep breath, then said, “Oh, nothing too big. We just are going to meet Ken a little sooner than we thought.”

“Yeah, we’re going to meet him downstairs so let’s go the elevator!” her father said.

“What about our food?” Jo asked.

“Don’t worry about it. We’re actually going to eat with Ken,” her mother said. They walked to the elevator and her father punched the button. A large boom echoed through the air. Shortly after, this the windows blasted inward spreading glass from the windows into the restaurant. Her father stepped in front of them blocking the glass. The glass shards rattled against his jacket before falling to the ground.

The elevator light turned off. “We’ll just take the stairs,” her mother said.

“Mommy, what’s going on?” Jo asked.

“It’s nothing. Just—” Her father was cut off by what sounded like an explosion. There wasn’t a flash of light, but something smashed against the building sending a rumble up through it. The floor began to shake.

“I’m scared!” Jo shouted. Her father looked toward her mother then back at her. The ground continued to waver beneath them. He grabbed the camera out of his bag and smashed it against the ground. He bent over and began to sift through the pieces. “What is Dad doing?” Jo asked. Her mother hugged her, hiding the building from her sight.

“Got it,” her father said. He stood up with a mirror in his hand. “Jo, remember how we practiced you going into the mirrors?” he

asked. Jo looked into the mirror. She saw the building and her mother, but not herself. She nodded. “Good. I need you to promise me something. Your mom and I are going to get out of here, but we need you to wait in here for just twenty minutes exactly.”

“Why?” Jo asked. Tears began to well in her eyes.

“Because your mom and I have a good plan to get out of here, but it only fits two people! So, just wait in here for exactly twenty minutes!”

“Why can’t we all hide in there?” Jo asked.

“Because we can’t all go in there, you know that, Sweetie!” her mother said. Dust fell from the ceiling coating the top of their head. Her dad took his glasses off, too dusty to see out of, and wiped his eyes. “Your father and I love you unconditionally,” she said. Her mother took the mirror out from her father’s hands and held it out to Jo.

“Un . . . con . . . dition . . . ah-we?” she asked.

“Unconditionally. Now please wait in there for us! We love you,” her father said. They all hugged before Jo began to enter the mirror. It’s hard to explain what it felt like to step into such a small mirror. The big ones were like walking through a door, but the small ones felt more like slipping between someone’s hands. Your body becomes putty forcing itself through the doorway. It was the last thing Jo remembered from her parents.

Once she had disappeared in the mirror, her dad grabbed a handkerchief out of his pocket and wrapped the mirror in it. They put the handkerchief in her mother's purse before placing purse inside her father's backpack. He ran to one of the broken windows and threw the backpack out into the air. He had enough time to give her mother one last hug before the building crumbled down.

2.

Dear Carol,

I leave things behind when I go out. Little things. Like I leave a relic I know I'll have to use or maybe a tool I may need. The funny thing is that no matter what I leave behind, I still manage to make it home. Somehow, I pull through each night. I guess I'm meant to be here still.

You'll never know how much I miss You. I'm not sure I would still be here if You hadn't been there for me after S-Day. I know, I talk about it too much. I'll stop mentioning it when it stops being true.

This world isn't what You wanted it to be yet. I fear I do not have enough time left to make it that way. I will try though. When You see me next, I want to be able to tell You she will have that world. I won't rest. This chance You gave me won't be wasted.

Love,

kenneth

Ken brushed the bristles of his broom against the ceramic floor in the hospital hallway, as he would most nights. While the lights were dimmed during the night shift, it was still bright enough for him to tell he wasn't actually catching anything. Nevertheless, he pushed the broom further down the hallway.

It was just him, his jumpsuit, the broom, and the occasional nurse that walked by who he shared a brief nod with. As he swept past each patient's room, he looked through the window in their door. Beyond the reflection of him and his white handlebar mustache, in every room a heartbeat sensor sat by a bed. In many it was connected to someone whose heart's readings were rhythmically given off. In nearly every room a patient lay asleep in their bed. In the lucky rooms someone sat asleep in a chair pulled to the side of the bed. In only a few of the rooms the person lying in the bed sat upright watching the TV. Although, none of these rooms had what Ken was waiting for.

He turned the corner to see a green light shining out from one of the rooms. It coated the floor in an unkempt aura that faded until it mixed back into the black shadows at the edge of its radius. Ken picked up his broom and spun it, so he held the stick forward as if it was a sword.

Ken slowly opened the door to the hospital room to see a patient asleep in their bed. Their pale skin was colored green, and the source of that unsightly hue floated above them. A ghost drifted in the air staring at the patient. Drool slipped out of the ghoul's mouth that spanned across the entirety of its rotund body. The saliva dripped onto

the patient but did not provoke a response. The ghost caressed the patient's face with its spongy phalanges as its yellow eyes looked the body up and down.

“The hell you think you’re doing?” Ken asked. The ghost did not stop ogling the patient's body. “You, floating and green. I’m talking to you. I can see you.” The ghost snapped its arm back from the patient's body and turned to face Ken.

Ken pointed his stick at the heart rate monitor, “You see that sensor? That beeping means they are still alive. You don’t get to eat until they are fully dead. Those are the rules.”

The ghost spoke in incoherent grumbles and grunts. As its tongue moved to pronounce syllables slime spit out onto Ken. “I get it, but they might still make it. They deserve the same chance all of us have. Go find some graveyard if you want to snack on some soul remnants.”

The ghost waved its hands in the air as it pointed to the unconscious patient. “Don’t make me sweep you on out of here,” Ken said. The bristles on his broom began to glow cyan. The ghost held their hands up in the air then turned to the window. It floated toward the wall and through it. Ken swept his broom against the ground and a light gust flowed across the patient pushing all the slime off them.

Ken exited the room then turned the corner and shuffled further down the hallway. He couldn’t help but wonder if that was the ghoul who had taken Carols’s soul. Once life was extinguished, there needed

to be something to remove what was left. This was a track of thoughts he attempted to avoid for there would never be a way to prove which spirit took her when her time had come. He turned the corner to see a blue light seeping out from another room, not necessarily a sign of alarm.

He approached the room and peered in to see another ghost floating above a different patient. This one was similar in shape to the last, except its arms were even longer and its skin was royal blue. “Two of them?” he asked himself as he opened the door. He stepped into the room and said, “Listen, I just told this to another one, you can’t be here while they are still living.”

“Who are you talking to?” a man asked. The ghost paid no attention to either of them. Ken turned to see a man no older than twenty standing in the corner of the room.

“Me? Oh, sorry. You know, these nights get kind of long, and I just tend to start talking to myself if I’m not careful,” Ken said followed by a short chuckle. He began to sweep the room in an attempt to remove the ghost while still making it look as if he was cleaning the floor.

“I imagine these nights must get long,” the man said. A slight breeze blew through the room and the ghost slowly floated away from the patient.

“Yeah, they do sometimes. They tend to keep me company though,” Ken said as he nodded toward the bed.

“Who?”

“The patients,” Ken said.

“Not very talkative company.”

“I suppose. I’d like to think they appreciate me for keeping an eye on them. Cleanliness is important in a hospital,” Ken said. The man stepped out of the corner and grabbed a leather coat that hung on a chair next to the bed.

“It got quite cold in here all of the sudden,” the man said. He walked over to the thermostat by the door.

“You’d think with how much they charge you, the hospital could just leave the heat on. How are you related to the patient?” Ken asked as he scraped the bristles across the ground in short, swift motions. Only the tip of the broom was alit with energy, just barely creating enough energy to push the ghost. He looked toward the window and saw that the ghost was beginning to cross over the barrier to the outside.

“Oh, I never said I was,” the man said twisting the bolt in the door, unbeknownst to Ken.

“Family friend?” Ken asked as the ghost finished crossing through the wall.

“Not quite,” he said. Ken nodded his head. The man reached into his back pocket and grasped the handle of a knife. Its wooden hilt shifted between his fingers as he stared at Ken aimlessly sweeping the

floor. He lunged at Ken. Ken brushed his broom against the ground and a gust of wind blew through the room knocking the man into a wall.

“Are you okay, Mister? I know this time in life can be stressful. Is there someone you would like me to call?” Ken asked.

“Do you see them too?” he asked.

“See what?” Ken asked.

“Don’t play dumb. You interrupted it. I saw what you were doing the whole time in this room.”

“I’m not sure what you are referring to,” Ken said.

“Wait a second. I know you. You used to work with the Nexus Magistrate, right? They warned me about you,” he said.

“Can’t say I’m familiar with the Nexus Magistrate.”

“They told me you were in the wind, Demon Duster. Didn’t expect to find you somewhere like here,” he said.

“I’m afraid you got the wrong guy,” Ken said. He picked a straw wrapper out of the bristles on his broom and put it in his back pocket.

“I know what you are, or were, capable of. Perhaps you’ve just become senile in your old age,” he said.

“I think that’s also pretty unlikely. I’ve been told I do a good job keeping the rooms clean.”

He circled around Ken who twisted his head to keep an eye on the man who spun the knife between his fingers. The blade now faced toward the ground. The man reached into the top of his jacket and pulled a leather hood out from it that had been tucked behind his back. He slid the hood over his head so it engulfed his face. The leather on the hood was crafted to mimic that of a cow's head with false ears sewn in, the letter x scratched into the fabric where the eyes would be, and patches of darker leather sewn across it.

“We are the Cattle, destined to save our Cowherd from the platitudes of this world. Through sacrifice, we can make our pitiful lives mean something, and help our leader form the better world he dreams of. Through sacrifice, we prevail.”

“Who said your life didn't mean something?” Ken asked. The man lunged at him and slashed the knife forward. Ken held his stick up horizontally to block the swipe then spun the stick around to jab him in the stomach.

“Let's take this one step at a time because this is quite frankly a large juxtaposition to where I was a few minutes ago.” As Ken spoke, he noticed the amulet hanging from the man's neck, “What are you doing with that Soul Siphon?”

“Don't you get it? It's not just my life that's meaningless, but their life is too,” he said as he pointed to the patient motionless in their bed, “and I was calling upon the spirits to take their souls so I could siphon them off for the Cowherd. You stopped this sacred process.”

“There should be no human sway on such matters. The ghouls arrive when they are meant to!” Ken said.

The man stepped forward and swung his knife out. Ken stopped it with the handle of his broom. The man pressed the blade against the broom stick with his right hand. Ken’s arms shook. As Ken pushed against the force of the knife, the man reached into his pocket and slashed a second knife forward with his left hand tearing through Ken’s jumpsuit. A gash appeared on his stomach and blood slipped out from it. Ken gasped then collapsed to the ground. His broom stick clattered against the tile rolling away from him.

The cultist climbed over him and raised his knives into the air.

“Three souls will have to be good enough!”

Ken reached up and tore the man’s amulet from his neck.

“Going to be hard to do without the siphon.” Ken reached for his broom head and scraped it against the ground, creating a gust of wind that knocked the cultist back against the wall. His skull cracked against it spraying blood out from his mouth with a gasp of air. Ken stood back up.

“I am so sorry . . . Cowherd. I failed you. One soul will have to be enough,” the man muttered. He held a knife loose in his left hand. He swung the knife toward his heart.

Before it could scrape the skin, Ken grabbed his arm to stop it.

“What the hell do you think you’re doing? God, you cults are so melodramatic,” Ken shouted without raising his voice to a volume where someone in the hallway would be able to hear it.

The man’s arm shook. He tried to pull the blade closer toward himself, “Let me do this for him. Let my life mean something!”

Ken ripped the knife from his hand and threw it to the other side of the room.

“No!” he cried out. “Why did you do that?”

“Why didn’t you swing deep enough to kill me?” Ken asked.

“I don’t know, I just swung out and I happened to graze you.”

Ken stepped back then looked up toward the ceiling. He sat down on the ground with a grunt and took deep breaths. He wiped sweat off his head. “Here’s what we’re going to do. I’m going to talk. You’re going to listen. Then, we are going to both leave here and act like none of this happened.”

The man looked toward the knife on the other side of the room. “I don’t need a lecture.”

“The whole sacrifice yourself for the leader schtick, real drawn out. The more progressive cults promote self-actualization nowadays.”

“You could never understand how the Cowherd thinks.”

“Maybe not, but I doubt they think how I do either.” Ken laughed then said, “I still hear her when it’s quiet. When I step outside

to drink my coffee on the porch, I hear her in the birds singing their morning songs and feel her when the wind blows through my hair. If I try hard enough, it feels like she's whispering to me. Isn't this world so beautiful?"

"What are you even talking about?" he asked.

Ken held the soul siphon in the palm of his hand. He felt the cold metal molded to mimic a small, deep bowl. Outside the window the parking lot sat mostly empty. "Care to tell me where I can find this Cowherd?" Ken asked.

"No."

"Well, I can always run a tracking spell on this siphon to see where it was leading to. I have all kinds of magical friends, so I am going to find out eventually. Might as well save me the time."

"You're lying. You can't track souls," he said.

"You'd be surprised how much work I've put into that field of study," Ken said.

"I'm not telling you anything."

"Fair enough. Still going to have to listen though."

The man shuffled on the ground, trying to make himself comfortable leaning against the wall.

"I have had run ins with the Eighty-four Sword Guild, the Oprachina, the Eel Clan . . . Hell, even the Nexus Magistrate is kind of

like a cult. They all have different ways of saying it, but really you all don't believe in the world anymore and I get it, I really do.

"The world isn't fair, and people don't always treat us right, but it needs to be a place that will treat those that come after us right. We need to help each other because it's what makes us human, and I don't mean like the flesh and blood part of it. Helping others is in our soul. That part of our soul can be in anyone or anything and they would be just as human as those of us with skin. It's what separates us from the evil monsters that lurk in the world. Our very essence is what empowers us to make it all right. I know it should have been fixed for us . . . or maybe we should have fixed it for you, but we didn't.

"I know we will leave here today, and your life won't be fixed. I know I could tell you this right now and as soon as you leave this building someone could stab you right in the back. Even knowing that, I am going to make the decision to care for you. I do this because she made the decision to care for me. I ask that you then care for someone else because I cared for you. That is the only way this world can ever be right. Every single life is valuable."

The man opened his mouth to speak, but stopped once the sound of footsteps could be heard from the hallway. They stared silently at each other in the hospital room with an unconscious patient in a bed right next to them waiting for the sound to cease. Once it did, he finally spoke.

"You promise we never see each other again?"

“If that is your wish,” Ken said.

“It is.”

“Fair enough,” Ken said. He stood up, grabbed the knife, and gave it back to the man. The man stood up then reached for the handle, but Ken gripped tightly to the blade. “Not going to stab me, are you?”

“No,” he said. Ken let go of the handle and reached into his pocket.

“You actually work here?” he asked.

“No, although I was a janitor back in the day for an elementary school. Nowadays I just use the janitor schtick as cover. While the kids loved me, being a janitor is a great way to make adults ignore me. Allows me to go where I need to protect who needs. By the way, name is Ken. Don’t really go by Demon Duster anymore. Pleasure to meet you.”

“Eli, likewise.” He took off the hood and slid it back under his jacket.

“Is this hospital thing widespread?” Ken asked while he dusted the floor to clean up their altercation.

“No, it was just my final effort to grab extra some souls before the final sacrifice.”

“Does this final sacrifice look like I think it will?”

“Yes.”

Ken sighed. “When is this final sacrifice?” he asked.

“Tomorrow night.”

“Suppose I should go stop that then. Where is it?”

“It’s . . . it doesn’t matter. Cowherd will kill you. He’ll kill me for telling you all of this.”

“He won’t get the chance if I stop him tomorrow.”

“You don’t get it. Each soul he absorbs is like another human’s strength added to his own. You could be fighting someone over a hundred times stronger than the average human.”

“I got some people I can call.”

“The Nexus Magistrate?” the man asked. He picked up a chair that had fallen over during their fight.

“No, damn near impossible to pull them out for anything not related to the Reckoning. I know some folk.”

“I can help,” he said. Ken finished cleaning the floor and walked over to him. He put his hand on Eli’s shoulder.

“Today was your battle. Tomorrow will be mine.”

“The final sacrifice. It’s in Cat’s Cradle, Louisiana. Not sure where. It’s got to be somewhere big. All the members will be there.”

“Better get moving then. Got a state to get across. Nice meeting you. Don’t let your past define you, today doesn’t have to be your reality,” Ken said. He began walking toward the door. “I forgive

you for tonight. Stay safe, Eli.” Ken departed leaving Eli alone in the room. No evidence of their scuffle remained. He slid the knife back into his pocket and straightened out the blanket covering the patient. His heart was still racing.

The man walked to the window and stared out at the parking lot. Beyond the parking lot a forest covered the horizon. A train’s horn echoed out in the distance. He cracked the window open just an inch. The humid air slid into the room with a cool breeze. Above, the moon shined on the cement reflecting a white hue off the cars down below.

Eli gripped the Soul Siphon and blinked. When he reopened his eyes, he could see hundreds of ghouls floating through the air. Their bulbous bodies drifted aimlessly searching for the next fading soul to feast on. They varied in color each shining their own in an aura around them. It looked as if paper lanterns were rising in the sky or small hot air balloons had filled the air. It was unsettling. It was beautiful.

3.

Dear Carol,

I forget what Your voice sounds like. I wish I could hear it. I try to be quiet and listen, but nothing. You'd hum to Yourself when You thought I couldn't hear You in the other room. When I close my eyes and try to listen all I hear is this ringing sound. I told someone I do hear You though. It's what he should hear. It's what he needed to hear. It's what I want to hear.

I'm off to fight something else. It shouldn't take long, but I don't think You'd want it to happen, so I'll stop it. Don't worry, I won't be going alone. Although You really have no reason to worry about me. Remember, I'm the one that doesn't die.

Love,

Kenneth

“And so you want my help to take down this Cowherd?” Rufus asked. He, his wife, and Ken sat on his porch. Crickets chirped out in the distance as Rufus and his wife, Mary, swung on a bench hanging to the roof of their porch with a few chains. Ken sat in a rocking chair. A half-dozen scented candles lined the rail of the porch to scare off bugs. The nearest house wasn’t for miles. Mary half-listened to their conversation while she focused her bifocals on the blanket she was crocheting. A previously completed blanket covered her legs to fight off the breeze.

“I do. I need a good hunter. I don’t know what we could be going into,” Ken said. He brushed his hand through Rufus’ border collie’s hair. The dog, Badger, was fairly old. His black hair had begun to fade and now he was mostly a silver color. His coat of fur had that oily dusty feeling old dogs got. He sat alert, yet with his head close enough for Ken to reach, while they spoke.

“Sounds like he needs you, Rue,” Mary said, still only looking at the blanket.

“You don’t need me. Go call on those magistrate friends of yours.”

“You know they wouldn’t come out for this. Besides, they’re too far away to make it in time. This is happening tomorrow night.”

“Go ask your niece for help.”

“No, I’m not getting her involved with this stuff,” Ken said.

“So, you’re stuck with me then? Listen, Ken. I really do appreciate you stopping by and all, but I couldn’t even catch that damn Ratman who was taking people from the next town over. Twenty years of people disappearing and nothing.”

“For all you know the Ratman just died of old age,” Ken said.

“Gah, I still remember that things’ yellow eyes. Remember when you fought him here? You tore up the storage shed,” Mary said.

“I do. Look, it should have been me who killed it. I owed it to the town.”

“That doesn’t invalidate all the other people you saved. You don’t have to come, but I’m going. It’s wha—”

“—What Carol would have wanted. Yeah, I know. What she wanted was for you to stop thinking about the past, not go fight some people dressed up as cows,” Rufus said.

“I’ll never be able to make up for what I did,” Ken said. Rufus rubbed his handlebar mustache, similar to Ken’s, but his was bushier and still had its black coloring.

“Just because something bad happened then, doesn’t make you a bad person now,” Rufus said.

“Look, you don’t have to come. It was nice seeing you,” Ken said. He stood up.

Rufus held his hands out then stopped the swinging bench with his boots. He stood up. "Fine. I'll come. One last mission. Can't have you going off and being a martyr."

"Want a cup of coffee for the road?" Mary asked.

"No, thanks though. Just let me get my stuff." Rufus swung the screen door open and entered the house. Ken followed behind him. Rufus' boots echoed off the wooden floor as he walked down the hallway. Countless animal skins lined the walls. To an untrained eye the werewolf pelt could have been confused for a wolf.

Rufus made a right and flicked on the light to the guest room. He threw the flower print quilt off the bed then with a grunt flipped the mattress over to reveal a suitcase. Rufus popped the clasps open and coughed, waving away the dust.

He pulled out a brown trench coat and a cowboy hat then put them on. "Go wet a napkin from the kitchen for me, would you?" Rufus asked.

Ken walked to the kitchen and dampened a napkin. In the kitchen, Mary was brewing a pot of coffee. When he returned Rufus now wore two rifle ammo slings, one on each shoulder. He held a dirt-streaked bolt-action rifle in his hand. Rufus took the napkin from Ken and cleaned off the barrel revealing the silver beneath.

"We're taking my truck by the way. I can't stand it when other people drive. They all do it wrong." Rufus slung the rifle over his back and exited the guest room.

They stepped back out onto the porch. Mary sat in the rocking chair crocheting. Two thermoses rested on the porch railing. “Aw, Mary. I said I didn’t want any coffee,” Rufus said.

“You will. Think you’ll be home for dinner tomorrow?”

“Probably not.”

“I’ll order something in for breakfast for us to eat the next day then,” she said. Rufus took off his hat and bent over to kiss Mary on the cheek. Ken looked way.

“No, I’ll bring something home for us to eat. I’ll surprise you.” Rufus put his hat back on. He pet Badger then stepped down the stairs to the porch. He beeped his silver truck before entering the driver’s side. Ken grabbed their thermoses then stepped into the passenger’s seat. Rufus backed the car up, honked the horn twice, then drove down their winding driveway.

The truck rocked side to side until they reached the road. “Where to?” Rufus asked.

“Bald Cyprus Forest.”

“You think they’re still there?” Rufus asked.

“I have a hunch they are.”

“Wow, we’re forming some type of superhero team or something. Nexus Magistrate, eat your pretentious hearts out.”

“No, that’s not what this is. It’s just some good people gathering to stop something bad.”

“Call it what you want, just punch that address into maps for me,” Rufus said.

Eli stepped out of his car and grabbed a pair of keys. When he unlocked the door to his apartment, he was distracted by a blue glow that appeared around him. He looked to the right and saw one of the blue ghouls floating just above him. It stared at him, unmoving, saliva dripping from its mouth.

“That’s weird. Why would that be—”

Eli was cut off by a cattle prod jutting through his stomach. Its pointed ends had torn out chunks of his flesh that were now glowing in the night air. The prod retracted back through his stomach.

“Should have known there is only one way out at this point,” a voice said from behind him.

Eli collapsed to the ground falling forward. “How . . . did . . . you know?”

“We are everywhere.”

4.

Dear Carol,

I am writing this from Rufus' car. That's why my handwriting is so bad. Doesn't explain the other entries though.

Yeah, I'm working with him again. In some ways it feels right. It feels like one of the old days. Between you and me, being here, with someone else, feels too close to it all. This whole fighting the cult... the action... the team. I can call it a gathering all I want, but I know what this is... a team of superheroes.

I can't do that again. The self-aggrandizing names. The belief that we are the ones to make the call for the greater good. The costumes so people worship us as concepts. No, I won't fall blind to that power again.

I think I'm doing something good here. I hope.

Sincerely,

Kenneth

Deep in the Bald Cyprus Forest, there was a creature that danced through the marshes guiding the animals in a parade celebrating the beauty that was nature. The alligators splashed in the water sharing a rhythm with the catfish that leapt through the air arcing over the monster. With each clap from the creature's hands, frogs croaked out in harmony. Turtles drifted in circles around the creature perfectly spaced out resembling synchronized swimmers. Above, egrets and herons covered the sky never drifting too far from the creature down below. They squawked in set patterns forming the backing track for their parade.

This creature shared the color of the dark-green algae that grew on the swamp's surface. It wore a hood hiding its face, but the tip of a snout resembling an alligator's stuck out from the shadows. When the creature got excited in the parade, the wings on its back folded out into the air. Its wings were featherless, instead, only a skeleton replica of the birds' the creature so admired, formed from wood the same color as the trees around it. With each clap sludge formed of mud and algae slopped off the creature's frog-like skin. The creature stood tall, almost tall enough to reach the lowest branches of the trees above.

Hearing the commotion, a colony of nutrias paddled through the swamp toward the creature. They used their tails to push through the water keeping their mouth above revealing their thick teeth. Once they got close enough to the creature, it lowered its arms so the nutrias could climb up onto it to sit on its shoulder. Together they all sang out in joy for this swamp was full of life.

Off in the distance, two hunters wearing waders were hunched over in the swamp. One of them wore a red hat to hide the hair he was losing. The other's thick beard hid his weak jawline and dipped into the swamp water coating the tip of it in algae. The hunter with the red hat stared down his sight, locking onto the Marsh Man dancing in the distance.

"You sure about this?" the hunter with the beard asked.

"I am. We finally caught him," the man with the hat said. Sweat beaded on his head slipping into his eyebrow. He looked away from the scope, wiped his face, then stared back down at the monster stomping through the forest. Enormous rats climbed across the creature and alligators swarmed the swamp guarding it. Its enormous, bony wings were spread out in the air casting a shadow across the water's surface. "Got you, you devil."

The jolt of the bullet rung out through the forest scaring the birds off into the distance. The cracking of the metal piercing the air echoed out for miles. It pierced Marsh Man and flew straight through the disheveled pile of organics that he called his body. The metal pieced through his leaves and mud and roots. It flew straight through him and into one of the nutrias.

In an instant the creature's body lost its grip on Marsh Man and flopped into the water. The bullet had pierced the creature's heart and within an instant it had died, mostly painlessly. Its body splashed into the water sinking under before rising back to the surface. The forest grew still.

“Shit. It went straight through the thing,” the man in the red hat said.

The alligators stopped splashing. The birds were far away at this point. The frogs grew silent. The catfish and turtles swam deep under and far away from the red-tinted water. The nutrias hopped off Marsh Man and swam across the swamp to be next to their fallen family member. Marsh Man picked up the nutria’s corpse with his steady hands, cradling the large rodent in his palms.

It let loose a roar. Ripples pushed out across the entire forest. The bald-cypress trees bent away from Marsh Man moved by the power in his cries. Marsh Man turned around. His yellow eyes stared at the two men.

Before they could even run, the algae in the swamp coalesced around them thickening the pools of water. Their legs were unable to move. The man in the red hat struggled to reload his gun as Marsh Man sunk back into the swamp.

“Come on! We need to get out of here!” the man with the beard said.

“I can’t move. I can’t even see it anymore.” The man with the hat turned around to see the bearded man be ripped underwater. The beginning of a yelp made it out before the swamp muffled his screams. Bubbles rose to the surface where he had been submerged. “Jason! Jason! Where are you?”

A mass of algae floated back up to the surface. It was bigger than a coffin and shaped as if it had formed around a body.

“Oh my god. Jason. Are you still alive?” the man with the hat shouted. He moved toward the mass of algae but was stopped by something in the water. Marsh Man’s glowing yellow eyes appeared in the water below. He rose up, his hood still perfectly covered his face, not even the tiniest bit soaked from the water. His yellow eyes looked down on him and his enormous organic form towered over the man.

~~“HEAT HAVE YOU BEEN?”~~

At the edge of Bald Cyprus Forest, Rufus pulled the truck into the parking lot and took the key out of the ignition. Before his car’s beams went out Ken saw the light shine through the forest. The trees cast thin, wavering shadows on one another making the forest appear as if it had no entrance. They exited then began to assess the surroundings.

Ken grabbed his broom and held the end of it up to a rusted sign illuminating the park’s open hours in a cyan light. Rufus reached into the back of the truck and grabbed a flashlight that he attached to the end of his rifle. He flicked it on, and a thin yellow beam shined out into the swamp.

“So, you think he’s going to be out in the swamp?” Rufus asked.

“It’s in his name, isn’t it?” Ken said.

“Marshes and swamps aren’t the same thing, tourist.” Rufus flashed a brief smile just barely visible from his flashlight’s aura. The swamp was silent. No crickets chirped, no birds flew above, not a single fish could be heard swimming. “Hear that?”

“Yeah, something’s wrong here. We need to move quickly. I need a pair of boots,” Ken said.

Rufus threw him a pair of black rubber boots. While Ken pulled them on Rufus said, “Hopefully this means the gators aren’t out too.”

“Why exactly do you live out here again?”

“Eh. Gumbo, crawfish, bananas foster,” Rufus said.

“I could go for some bananas foster. Know a place around here?”

“A few. Depends where we end up,” Rufus said. Ken finished putting on the boots. They entered the swamp. Ken held his broom up at the ready while Rufus scanned the horizon with his rifle. They waded through the swamp for nearly ten minutes without seeing a single living creature.

It was silent until a scream echoed out. “Please! I—I’m sorry. I didn’t mean to!” Ken turned toward Rufus who nodded in agreement. They began to run in the direction of the scream. After passing through the trees, they reached a clearing. In this clearing, Marsh Man stood in the water dangling a man in the air above alligators that circled below. On a nearby tree a cocoon of dried algae hung from a branch.

~~"Can you hear it? The forest is crying. This life was taken, and our world will never be the same. All because of you!"~~

"I don't understand—I don't understand what you're saying!" the man screamed out. Marsh Man lowered him closer to the water.

Ken ran out into the clearing. "Hey! Knock it off! You're going to kill him!"

Marsh Man lifted the man back up and turned toward Ken.

~~"Demon Buster? What are you doing here?"~~

"The better question is what are you doing here? We don't kill people!" Ken shouted. Rufus stepped out from the trees with his rifle slung over his back. He gave a quick wave but stood far back from the commotion.

"Hey! You—help me, Dude! You got to save—," algae formed around the man covering him in a coat of green hiding his face. Marsh Man walked over to a tree and stuck the cocoon to it. He walked off, grabbed something out of the swamp, then returned to Ken. He cupped the dead nutria in his hands, its fur now soaked and stained green.

~~"Look what . . . Look what he did . . ."~~

"Oh, God. I'm so sorry. They didn't deserve that fate. I hope it was quick."

~~"How would you feel if someone came into one of the hospitals you were guarding and killed someone under your care? This creature~~

was no different than the vulnerable people in the hospitals you protect. He had thoughts and feelings. This I know."

"I . . . I don't know. I am truly sorry for your loss, for this world's loss," Ken said. He put his hand on Marsh Man's arm, slightly depressing the formation of algae and mud that formed him. Marsh Man let out a noise somewhere between a groan and a cry. It reverberated through the forest. He collapsed into the swamp falling to his knees. Ken put his hand on Marsh Man's shoulder. "I understand why you were attacking them. Let's just take them back. They didn't know any better, but it can stop now. More death doesn't bring back the dead."

"We'll help you bury the little guy. I got a shovel in the truck," Rufus said, still hanging toward the back.

"Who is he? Why are you both here?"

"Name's Rufus, friendly," he said.

"We came to find you. I need your help. There's more death coming," Ken said.

"Bury him, then we talk."

Marsh Man sat by a cross formed from twigs and vines. His enormous form lurched over the grave. His palm was to the ground, feeling the forest. Rufus pat the dirt with the back of his shovel. Ken stared at a map watching Rufus finish the burial. He sat in the

passenger seat of the truck with the door open. Two cocoons of algae were in the bed of the truck. They would drop them off in town on their way to their destination.

~~"I should have protected him."~~

"It wasn't your fault. Think about all the other animals you keep safe," Rufus said.

~~"His parents aren't even able to understand he's dead. To them he's just gone, perhaps to return tomorrow."~~

"Maybe it's better that way."

Marsh Man looked to the rifle on the ground behind Rufus.

~~"How are a hunter?"~~

"Used to be. If we had met a few decades ago, chances are I would have been the one shooting at you. Although, I'd like to think I have a better sense of the good and bad monsters than those two did. Only tried to kill things that deserved it," Rufus said. Marsh Man looked away from Rufus. He finished patting down the dirt and sat down next to Marsh Man in front of the grave. "Look, I'm really sorry about your loss."

~~"Thank you."~~

"Don't mention it. You know my story, it's pretty dry, so, what's your story?"

~~"I don't know."~~

“You do call yourself Marsh Man. Were you like some guy that took a tumble into a radioactive swamp?”

~~“Others call me that. I am not sure if I am a man. I am just
‘That’”~~

“Far as I’m concerned you got a good heart under all that mush. That makes you man enough to me if you want to be,” Rufus said. Ken finished reading the map then sat down next to the two of them.

“It looks nice,” Ken said. “We’re about an hour out from Cat’s Cradle and there’s a small village just ten minutes out from here. We can drop off the hunters and then camp about twenty minutes outside of town.”

“Camp? Why don’t we just stay in town?” Rufus asked.

“It’s a small town. Don’t think I’d like to close my eyes there.”

~~“I do enjoy camping. I will ask the bugs to leave us alone.”~~

“I appreciate it. Take as much time as you need here and then we can get going. We got about five hours until sunrise. Rufus will drive and you can ride in the back.”

~~“I’m ready. Let us cease this senseless death.”~~

5.

Dear Carol,

I'm riding in the car with Rufus and Marsh Man now. It's been a while since I've seen him. Being a part of this gathering... it's something else. Regardless of what you could call us, I am happy to see some old friends.

Out here it's so quiet. I know what that ringing is. It's Sunday. I hear their screams. The fact that I even played a small part in it...

We'll be camping outside of Cat's Cradle. It's a nice night. I can see a lot of stars out here. I don't usually get to see them in the hospital. I hope you can see them too. When I go to bed tonight I

“What in the hell is that?” Rufus asked. The car jolted to a stop. Ken looked up from his notebook to see what appeared to be a cross out to the side of the road. They were on a back road, not a light in sight. The night had become foggy as they drove closer to Cat’s Cradle. Marsh Man stood up in the trunk rocking the car. Rufus backed the truck up and turned it to the side, so his high beams illuminated the cross. It looked like something was attached to it.

They got out of the truck and walked off into the grass closer to the cross. It was made of two large planks of wood nailed to each other. The light revealed a man’s body hanging off the front of the cross. Cattle prods were jammed through his hands and feet anchoring him to the wood. Blood dried black coated the right side of the man’s face. It originated from a circular imprint on the side of his head. Bugs hovered around the corpse dipping their legs in each streak of blood. It seemed that many of the bugs had dug into the gash on the man’s stomach feeding on what remained. The man’s eyes were open, and his head hung forward, staring at the ground.

Ken looked at the man’s clothes. He was wearing the same style of jacket Eli was wearing.

“It’s one of the cult members.” Ken assessed the size of the imprint on the man’s head. It was about the size of a quarter. “I think they killed him with a bolt gun, like they use for cattle, or . . . maybe. I don’t know what happened to him.” Ken stared closer at the man’s face. He turned around and began to pace.

Rufus stepped up to the cross. The truck was behind them shining its lights so he cast a shadow on the cross. His cowboy hat created a distinct outline. “Oh my god. I—I can get the shovel. We can’t leave him like this.”

~~“Let me handle it this time.”~~ Marsh Man stepped forward. He extended his hand out and closed the man’s eyes. ~~“Bugs, leave this man alone. He has suffered enough.”~~ The bugs darted through the air disappearing back into the darkness. Marsh Man knelt on the ground and pushed his palm against the grass. The earth around them began to shake and slowly the cross sunk into the ground. Marsh Man hummed to himself. He put another palm to the ground. The cross continued to lower into the earth until all that was left was a patch of dirt.

“You know, it’s crap like this that made me stop doing this. I’m too old for this stuff. I’ve already seen all I can see . . . I mean Christ almighty . . . what happened to the world?” Rufus asked.

Ken stopped pacing. His insides turned in on themselves. Something was caught in his throat, and he tried to push it back down with deep breaths. For some reason there was a churning in his stomach. It felt like he was still pacing even though he stood still. The cool night air suddenly felt suffocating. He lurched over and coughed then gagged. Chunks of vomit flew up his throat in a stream that he spewed out into the grass.

“Ken! Woah. Are you all good there?” Rufus asked. He ran over then tried to grab Ken’s shoulder and brace his hand on his back.

“Don’t get close to me!” Ken stumbled farther away dragging his boots through the vomit on the ground. “That man. It’s—That is— That was Eli. He was the one that told me about this all! They must have found out. I got him—It’s because of me that—” Ken spewed out another stream of vomit that splashed against the grass. Rufus ran to the truck to get the thermoses. “I was supposed to save them! That was the point of this all! This is just what happens when I try to get involved. S-Day happened when I tried to be a hero. That zombie outbreak happened when I worked with the Nexus Magistrate. Now, I got Eli killed by trying to be a hero again! I must be cursed.” Ken wiped his mouth then flicked the vomit on his hand off into the grass. Marsh Man reached to the ground and the grass folded in on itself burying the vomit.

~~“Tough extracts a heavy toll.”~~

“Here, take a drink. Come on. Get the taste out of your mouth,” Rufus said. He passed a thermos over to Ken who took a swig of coffee before gasping for air. “So, they know we’re coming I suppose.” Rufus pat Ken on the back and led him to the passenger seat of the truck.

“He was . . . He had to be about the same age as Jo,” Ken said. He sat down in the passenger seat.

“But it wasn’t her. Jo is off at school not dealing with any of this magic stuff,” Rufus said. Marsh Man climbed into the bed of the truck. “There’s a camping spot a few minutes down the road. Let’s set up shop and call it a night.”

They drove off to the campsite, but Ken was no longer thinking about the night. No, he was thinking about Eli's bloodied face. It looked so similar to the boy's face twenty some years before. The kid went by Spark Starter, or at least Ken thought so. There hadn't been much time for names once the fighting started. His orange and white suit hissed, loose wires sparking against the rubble he laid in.

The armor prevented Ken from getting a pulse on the boy, but when he saw a ghoul drift down, he knew. There had been so many of them in the air that day. Hovering around, waiting for it all to start. It was like they knew it was going to happen. There wasn't a chance to bury Spark Starter. Ken had to keep moving before another hero found him.

Carol would tell him he had no choice. That he had to do what he had to do to make it out of there. That he gave Spark Starter every chance possible to leave him be. When the heroes turned on one another there were no distinct sides. Who had remained an ally and who was now foe was unclear. After S-Day, Ken looked Spark Starter up online. He had almost graduated from college. Both his parents were still alive. He had a name. A real name. Samuel Broley. And Samuel was dead.

6.

They laid out to camp at a park accompanied by various campers with their lights off. At this time of night, the families had gone to sleep. Rufus kept a few sleeping bags in the back of the truck. He rolled out three of them on the ground. Marsh Man grazed his fingers against the ground and the grass underneath the gravel flourished creating padding for them.

“Don’t stray too far. No need to scar any of the kids,” Rufus said.

“~~How about this?~~” Marsh Man clenched his fists and the organic matter forming his body pushed inward becoming denser. His body shrunk to the size of a normal human. His hood disappeared and his head took the shape of a human’s. In the night he looked just like anyone else although the yellow eyes would give him away if you got too close. Marsh Man nuzzled himself in a green sleeping bag while Ken padded down his blue one.

Rufus set a lamp in the center then adjusted his red bag. Through the trees they could just barely see the moon shining down on them. Ken laid down and rubbed his hands across his eyes.

“It’s not your fault, Ken,” Rufus said.

“I know . . .”

“We’re going to get this guy. I may have failed my town, but I won’t fail here. Not today,” Rufus said. He stretched out and rested his cowboy hat over his face. Crickets chirped off in the distance and the hum of the night’s insects vibrated through the air. Thanks to Marsh

Man they never got too close. An occasional frog croaked out. The night air was cool but not cold. It was dense but not heavy.

~~"It's a beautiful night. We have failed in the past, but the world is still beautiful."~~

"Yeah, the world can be real funny like that. Camping out like this reminds me of when I was in the Scouts. You know, archery, canoeing, powdered potatoes, BB guns, the whole nine yards. Loved those nights with my dad.

"Funny thing is I remember this one year. It's a week-long trip and this specific year we went back home one night cause the basement flooded. Nothing crazy but some old photos got all washed up. Anyways, cleaned that up and my dad and I went back to camp.

"Guess what?" Rufus asked.

~~"What?"~~

"Day after that my dog trips and falls. Real nasty; ruptured a tumor and stuff. So, my dad went back home again to take her to the vet to be put down. I was so young, and I just couldn't do it, so I stayed at camp. I had just seen her healthy the night before. Maybe I should have been there but . . . Anyway, I was just a kid.

"The troop leader watched over me. He was an old guy. Real caring and stuff. I remember crying in my tent and he lightly pat my back saying it would all be okay. I think he was afraid to touch me, scared of being accused of anything. I carry on camping and my dad

comes back that night. It had been taken care of,” Rufus said. He sighed.

~~“I am sure you loved her well.”~~

“Thanks. I guess . . . I guess my point is I remember that. It’s what I think about camping out here, but I don’t hate camping. I still went camping the following years even knowing horrible things could happen when I was gone. I still enjoyed making smores, not showering, swimming in the pond, and all that stuff. Bad things happened but camping was still good.”

It appeared as if Ken laid in his sleeping bag sound asleep. He heard Rufus tell his story but did not respond. Instead, he kept his eyes closed and continued to pretend.

“S-Day happened. It happened a while ago. It was a bad thing, but you are good, Ken. I just wish you could see that,” Rufus said. He set his head on the ground and flicked the lamp. “G’night you two.” When Rufus looked at Ken, he didn’t see someone who had failed. No, Ken had fought. He had been put in a no-win situation and did his best. At least he did something. Ken didn’t just let something happen without at least intervening, not like he had himself.

~~“Sleep well.”~~

Ken continued to keep his eyes closed. Images flashed across his mind. He saw Spark Starter. He saw Jo on S-Day. He saw his wife. He saw the Nexus Magistrate. He saw Zombie. He saw Crimson Claw.

He saw the man from the hospital. But most of all, he saw the man hung on the cross. His lips wavered, but he maintained his composure.

He mouthed words to himself, unable to be heard over the sounds of the night.

“You’re a good person.”

“You’re a good person.”

“You’re a good person.”

“You do good things.”

“You do good things.”

“It’s not my fault that bad things happen. It’s not . . . It’s not my—” Ken stopped speaking out of fear his voice may crack and the others would hear him. Perhaps if he uttered these words enough he would believe them. Maybe for just one night he could see himself how his friends saw him.

7.

A father and his son laid on a field. It was nighttime and their house was off in the distance. The lights were on, coating that surrounding area yellow. A buoy in the darkness. Crickets chirped in the distance and the air smelled of citrus keeping the mosquitos away. They stared up at the stars twinkling in the sky. Fireflies faded their light in and out crossing over them.

This man was more than a father. He was once a kid whose father sat with him outside. He'd always wanted to do this with his own son someday. In fact, a child was all he ever wanted. Someone to raise. A chance to make the world just a little bit better. Someone to imprint the best parts of himself so they could carry them on once he departed.

But now he was there. He was the father and his son wanted answers. Answers to questions he didn't know.

"He's up there somewhere, Rufus. Watching over us."

"When will he come back down to see us?" the kid asked.

"I'm afraid that Dixon is going to have to stay up there."

"I miss him. He was a really good dog."

"He was."

"I still love him. Can I still love him if I can't see him anymore?" Rufus asked.

"Of course you can. I'll always love him too."

“He was kind of old, wasn’t he?”

“He lived a good life. Just eventually they have to move on. I’m sure he’s happy now. Remember how much he was hurting? It wouldn’t have been fair to keep him here.”

“Is he alone up there?” Rufus asked.

“No, my dogs from when I was a kid were there to greet him. They’re all running around together now. Not to mention my dad is up there so they have someone to throw things for them. Then Dixon will welcome the next dog of ours when their time comes.”

“I’m really sad. I’m not sure if I want another dog. I don’t want to lose him too.”

“Everyone has got to go someday. Doesn’t mean that time you spend with them doesn’t matter. They’ll always be alive up here,” the father said. He pointed to his head.

“I don’t want you to leave me, Dad.”

“Don’t worry, Rufus. I’m not going anywhere anytime soon.”

“But your dad left when I was a baby. I want to be a dad like you too, but what if you also go soon after my baby?”

“Then I’m happy to have met my grandchild.”

The father and son continued to stare up at the sky. Perhaps if they looked at it long enough, they would be able to see the stars

move, if not just a little. They had to move just like anything else and in the morning, they would be gone.

8.

Dear Carol,

It's days like these I think about family, or at least what I still have of it anymore. I hope Jo is doing well. I know she must be. She had my sister's wits and level-headedness. Jo has a good head on her shoulders.

I can only hope my work out here works to make her safer. She deserves it. At the least, I ask for some sort of cosmic karma to repay what I have done in such ways. That's supposing I have good karma coming my way. I know you'd tell me I have paid it back by now, but you weren't there. You didn't see him. You didn't see what I did to him. I'm not sure if there is salvation for people like me.

I won't stop until I earn that good karma.

Love,

Kenneth

"I'll just take the usual," Rufus said setting down the menu.

This is your first time here . . ." the waiter said. He rolled his eyes, loudly chewing gum.

"I see. Well, in that case I'll take the breakfast special . . . and do you guys do banana foster?"

"You mean bananas foster?"

"Yeah, that's the one. I also want one of those to go, so skip the ice cream," Rufus said.

Ken, Rufus, and Marsh Man sat at a booth in Sally's Supper Shack which was a diner located just at the border of Cat's Cradle. The leather on the booth was blue and little cardboard recreations of sea creatures hung from the ceiling. Yacht rock played in the background underneath the sound of plates and people talking. The booths on either side of them were full.

"I'll try the fish and egg sandwich," Ken said. "Sailing" by Christopher Cross played over the twenty-year-old speakers.

"That's foul," Rufus said.

"It's our special. It's actually relatively well received by the locals," the waiter said before blowing a bubble with his gum and popping it.

"~~Water~~"^{fk} Marsh Man muttered. He was in his more human-appearing form in a trench coat with a large fedora on. "~~No ice. Please~~"^{fk}

"Can do, but I'll have to charge you a buck for the water. Diner policy," the waiter said.

"That's fine with me. Thanks a ton," Ken said smiling at the waiter while he walked off. "Alright. We need to talk about some pressing matters."

"Yeah, who eats fish and egg together? That just doesn't even sound right," Rufus said.

"We got to look natural. Besides, I usually eat hospital food anyway."

"~~This town is . . . unnatural. I feel a vacuum of nature,~~" Marsh Man said.

"We've got to figure out where Cowherd is here and we have to do it by tonight," Ken said.

"Well, there's only so many places in town. Can't be too hard. I say we start with the churches," Rufus said.

"I'd be surprised if they let us just snoop around like that," Ken said. Rufus scratched his mustache with the back of his hands as he stretched his shoulders.

"...so this is starting in about ten hours. That means we need to get to the old opera hall before then..." a voice from the booth behind them said. Ken tilted his head toward the booth behind them just enough so his ears could barely face the conversation.

"Surely they will know we are coming," an electronic voice said. It sounded just like Spark Starter's voice did when he was in his suit.

"There's no way Cowherd knows we're onto him. I've made sure of it, Janus," the first voice said again. That first voice. It was familiar to Ken. He'd heard this woman speak before, but where? "We

hit them hard and fast." She was interrupted by the waiter who returned to their table.

"I have your fish and egg sandwich, Miss. And for you, I have your dry cereal." Ken could hear the waiter set down a plate then a bowl on the other table.

"Thank you," the two people at the other booth said.

"Janus, you need to be careful always ordering dry cereal. Someone's going to catch on to us if you keep ordering weird things."

"I just like to study them. So many different flavors. Besides, you're the one who ordered the fish and egg sandwich."

Ken's listening was interrupted by Rufus who said, "Woah, look that woman over there also got that weird sandwich. You know, she kind of looks like—"

Ken turned around, "Jo? Is that you?" He turned to see the back of who he presumed to be Janus' head. Janus' skin was covered mostly in purple cloth with a long scarf, coat, and pointy hat. Where he could see Janus' skin, it was silver. He looked past Janus to see Jo sitting at the table, sandwich in hand. Her curly black hair was tied into a bun. She wore a black cloak with a red inside lining and a gold pin connecting the two ends around her neck.

"Uncle Ken? Uncle Rufus?" she asked.

"Oh my god! Come sit over here you two," Rufus said. He scooched in on his side of the booth right up against Marsh Man so there would be room for one person on both sides of the booth. Jo and Janus picked up their dishes and moved to their booth.

“What in God’s name are you doing here? How’d you get here?” Ken asked Jo.

“Same thing you are. Here to stop a cult.”

“You’re supposed to be at college out east. How are you all the way out here?” Ken asked.

“College wasn’t the thing for me. Not conducive for vampiric individuals to flourish.”

“Then where has the money I’ve been routing gone too?” Ken asked.

“Well, you did ask how I got here . . .”

“Jesus . . . Jo, you need to take this stuff seriously. It’s what your parents would want.”

“I am taking this seriously. Maybe you’d have found out I dropped out if you checked in on me more than once a year.”

“I’ve . . . I’ve been busy . . .”

Janus ate her cereal piece by piece as the two of them reconnected. She lifted each piece one-by-one up to her face. A panel would slide open, and she would plop the piece in. Marsh Man watched her do this. He could hear each piece clink against the inside of her metal torso. Rufus watched Ken and Jo talk unsure if this conversation would end with reconnection or further distancing.

~~“Sure is taking a bit for water,”~~ Marsh Man said.

“Yeah, a little weird. Especially cause it isn’t too busy here,” Rufus said. He looked around to see that they were the only ones at the diner now. Their waiter pushed through the swinging doors to the kitchen with a tray in his hands. “Speak of the devil!”

The waiter approached the table. He put a fish and egg sandwich on the table then put down the breakfast special in front of Rufus. It was comprised of scrambled eggs, bacon, and toast.

“And finally, the water for you,” the waiter said. He put the glass of water in front of Marsh Man. “So, you all know each other?”

“Never know who you’ll meet around these parts!” Rufus said.

“Seemed like you all knew each other. Hmm. Funny . . . Enjoy your meal! Stop me if you need anything,” the waiter said. He walked back off to behind the kitchen.

Rufus cringed making a sound almost like that of a cat hissing watching Ken and Jo eat their sandwiches. Rufus picked up a piece of bacon and ate the whole thing all at once.

“You seeing this?” Rufus asked, still chewing his food.

“I have no concept of taste,” Janus said.

“I see you eating the remains of an animal,” Marsh Man said.

“Come on, Man. Not cool to bring up when it’s in my mouth,” Rufus said. He swallowed and began to lather his toast in butter. “And what about them two? They’re eating fish.”

“Fish are not quite the same.”

“Great. We got a pescatarian here. You know, who says you can draw the line on sentience?” Rufus asked.

“I am the embodiment of all that is natural. I am its shield and sword when need be. I know all there is to know.”

“Mmk. And with all that you made a tier list for animal sentience?”

~~“Yes,”~~ Marsh Man said. Jo continued to eat her sandwich almost done with it. Ken had taken one bite of his then set it back down. The mix of cooked eggs and fish left an interesting aroma in the air.

“What do you think, Uncle Ken?”

“Not sure if I’m sold,” Ken said.

“I think it tastes great.”

“Yeah, well you like blood and stuff so your palette is all types of messed up,” Rufus said. “No offense though.”

“None taken.”

“You know . . . I must have not gotten a lot of sleep last night. I feel kind of rough right now,” Ken said. The room began to spin around him. He struggled to keep his eyelids open. It felt as if he hadn’t slept for days. He couldn’t feel his legs. They sat motionless beneath no matter how much he tried to use them.

“Probably the smell getting to you,” Rufus said.

~~“I slept fine,”~~ Marsh Man said.

“Actually . . . You know . . . now that you mention it, I am feeling a little sleepy,” Rufus said. Jo slumped forward, her head crashing against her plate.

"Jo, are you okay?" Janus asked. She shook her to no avail.

"Not sure if I want these people's banana foster..." Rufus trailed off then slumped backward in the booth.

Marsh Man looked out the window. A half-dozen of Cowherd's followers were approaching the building.

~~"We have been found out. We must depart."~~ Marsh Man said.

"They got us . . . surrounded. Rufus, Jo, and I are in no shape to fight. You two need to get out of here." The color slipped from Ken's face. He shook Jo's shoulders, but she remained passed out on the table.

"I'm not leaving her," Janus said.

~~"They likely prepared countermeasures for the two of us since poison would be ineffective. We need to take this chance to escape."~~

"Just go . . . I'll keep us safe until you can find us," Ken said. His eyes grew heavier. Janus summoned a portal and looked back before flying into it. Marsh Man decompressed his body, so it was just a pile of sludge, and he slid out one of the back doors. Ken could hear the bells at the entrance ring as his head fell forward.

9.

Dear Carol,

I think about my mistakes a lot. I guess I just think about how things could have gone differently. I run through the scenario over and over. I try to think about each decision. I'm not sure if I'm just trying to get the story straight or maybe I'm trying to think hard enough to believe it went differently.

I know I really shouldn't. The more I think about these things the more the story seems to warp in my head. I just feel obligated to my mistakes. I need to see them all the way through. I should feel all the repercussions. I don't know. I miss you.

Love,

kenneth

“I need you to step out of my way,” Demon Duster said. The end of his broom was lit aflame with cyan energy that made his white jumpsuit glow an almost supernatural hue.

“You know I can’t do that. Too much shit going down here. I’m deciding that no one gets in or out until we sort this out!” Spark Starter said. The metallic boots to his suit clinked against the ground once his thrusters turned off. The sun shined off his orange and white suit reflecting rays of light onto nearby buildings. His mask was painted orange with his boots and gloves matching. The rest of his suit was painted white. What Ken would remember most about his suit was the intricate orange pylon painted on his chest.

“Look around us! It’s too late for that. There’s no sorting this out.” Around them screams echoed from behind the skyscrapers of Hope City. Above, a hero in a purple suit shot out of a building raining glass down on them. A hero with a green cape, who had presumably thrown him, blasted through the building grabbing the man in the purple suit midair then throwing him toward the street. Rays of various colored lights shot through the sky illuminating the clouds of debris they were standing in. The smell of smoke burned Ken’s nose. “My family is just a few blocks down. I need to get to my sister and her family.”

“Yeah, well, then I got my dad a few blocks behind you,” Spark Starter said. He began to walk forward, his boots clinking against the ground. He rubbed his hands charging electricity between

them. Spark Starter pulled his hands apart and played with the electricity letting it bounce between his hands.

Ken continued to step back. “I don’t want to fight you. Please.”

“I don’t want to fight you either. Just lay low until this is over and we don’t have to fight.”

“You’re not listening to me—This isn’t about me. Who knows what has happened to them. I have a niece. She’s just a kid.”

“A niece? Funny. Figured it’d at least be a son or something. Not everyday someone is willing to die for a niece. Kind of distant family, don’t you think? Shouldn’t be an issue to stay in your place. Should it?” Spark Starter asked.

“You’re a hero. I am too. We’re meant to save people. That doesn’t have to change today.”

“To be honest, not sure which way is up right now. I think I’ll just do what I think is right!” Spark Starter shouted. He thrust his hands forward, and electricity shot outward toward Ken. He rolled to the side just barely dodging it. The beam shot past him crashing into a building sending out a plume of dust. “I’m not scared of some janitor.”

“You should be,” Ken said. He stood back up and gripped the broom in his hand. The wooden handle vibrated from the magical energy he had been storing up in it. Jo and them were only a few more blocks away. Ken spun the broom in the air then slammed the head of it against the ground sending a shockwave of cyan energy outward.

Spark Starter activated the thruster in his suit and flew over the attack. Ken flicked the broomstick, and a burst of air crashed against Spark Starter knocking him back into a building before falling to the ground. Spark Starter's helmet cracked and the electronics within began to fizzle in and out. While he struggled to rip the helmet off, Ken ran toward him.

He lifted the broomstick into the air and slammed it down. Spark Starter stopped it before the bristles could contact his suit with the back of his right arm. He thrust out his left arm and a shock of electricity burst outward. It flew into Ken's body and instantly spread across his skin.

Dazed by the shock, Ken was unable to dodge the uppercut. Spark Starter's metallic fist slammed against the bottom of Ken's jaw sending him spinning through the air. His broom landed on the ground next to him.

Spark Starter threw off his helmet. The orange metal clinked across the ground. Ken could feel the vibrations of his boots clanking on the road before he was able to open his eyes.

"Stand down." He heard Spark Starter speaking, his voice now clear without the helmet on. Ken opened his eyes to see Spark Starter's right fist glowing yellow.

He looked up to see Spark Starter's face. His hair was black and cut short. He couldn't have been much older than twenty. A scar covered the skin at the peak of his right cheek bone.

“You’re—You’re just a kid. Who gave you that scar?” Ken asked.

“I’m not a kid,” Spark Starter said. He stood above Ken, his fists clenched. Ken stretched his arm out reaching his fingers toward the broom. Spark Starter kicked the broom, and it clattered away from them.

“Last time I’ll ask. Just let me go,” Ken said.

“You’re in no position to be making demands,” Spark Starter said. Ken reached his arm out and his hand began to glow cyan. The broomstick flew back toward him. Spark Starter observed this revelation in Demon Duster’s powers, briefly stunned at his underestimation, but he still managed to slam his fist downward just as Ken got the broom.

In retort to Spark Starter’s punch downward, Ken held the broom up and blocked the electric punch with the magical energy flowing across the broom. Spark Starter continued to push downward as Ken pushed up. The cyan and yellow light combined to coat the area in a sickly green.

Spark Starter charged up his other fist then slammed it down and the combined force broke Ken’s broom into two pieces. The wood splintered and the cyan color immediately left the broom once it was no longer one. Ken tilted his body to the side avoiding the fists’ downward movement into the road. Ken kicked his foot against the

front of Spark Starter's shins, and he fell forward. Ken thrust the broken top half of his broom upward.

The wooden edge pierced right through Spark Starter's throat and out the back of his neck. Spark Starter fell onto Ken. The kid slipped a few more inches down the stick but stopped before making contact with Ken who held the stick upward with the back of it against the ground, propping Spark Starter above him. Blood slipped down the wood and onto Ken's hands.

"What kind of . . . what kind of . . . hero . . ." Spark Starter sputtered spraying blood out from his mouth before his head slumped forward. With a grunt, Ken threw Spark Starter off himself. He grabbed both parts of his broom and looked briefly at Spark Starter sprawled out on the ground before continuing his approach to Jo.

10.

A green portal appeared in between two trees. Janus floated through it into the woods far away from the diner. It would be natural for someone to respond to these circumstances with fear or trepidation. After all, the charade was up. Cowherd was on to them. Although Janus was not of the natural sort. Instead, she sat down next to a tree and began to calculate how she would save Jo along with her uncle.

Distracted by the various scenarios racing through her mind, Janus did not notice the pile of leaves rolling across the ground picking up moss and twigs until Marsh Man stood next to her.

He flicked her on the head, "Get up. We must save our friends."

Janus' eyes lit back up green, and she turned to Marsh Man, "That is what I'm doing. I am running through potential ideas."

"How complicated would it be? Just teleport them out."

"It is not that simple. My portals don't work on organic material or things with a soul. Same reason I could only save myself."

"I've never heard of such restrictions on magic."

"Nor have I heard of a mix between swamp and man. Doubt you have ever encountered a robot that can perform magic before. Magic is nothing more than the projection of oneself. Perhaps an average human could transport people via portals," Janus said. She stood back up then brushed some leaves off her cloak. "Alas, normal human I am not. Seeing you here does introduce a new factor though. What if I were to teleport you in?"

"I do not think that is possible," Marsh Man said looking down to the ground.

"Are you so sure about yourself?" Marsh Man turned to face away from Janus. He dragged the back of his hand down the bark of a tree feeling the moss tickle his form.

"Thank you for viewing me so kindly. Why would you not just teleport yourself in?"

"And then do what? I have no idea what I am engaging with at the concert hall."

"How can teleport most anything. Seems like a lack of creativity to me."

"Then describe your optimal scenario for me because I cannot process sending anything in that would disarm our opponents while leaving our friends unharmed."

"I do not know," Marsh Man walked across the forest floor. He could always feel the ground beneath him, but it wasn't quite like how humans felt the earth beneath them, at least how he imagined they did. It wasn't one cohesive sensation but instead a speckling of feeling as the living parts of his body dragged against the ground.

"So, why are you so sure of yourself?" Janus asked.

"It's not that I am. I just do not think I am ready to know what I am."

"The time for trepidation has passed."

~~"You would not understand!"~~

"I wouldn't? I know I have no soul."

~~"But you always knew!"~~ Birds ruffled out of the trees squawking as they flew into the sky. The forest grew silent because the bugs paused to hear his next words. Not even the mosquitoes dared buzz.

"Who cares? Why is your only focus having a soul? I don't feel as if I am missing any parts. I act as lively as any other human and share connections just the same as a soul-having person would. My life is still meaningful."

They stood together. Silent in the forest.

~~"But where will you go when you die?"~~

"I am unsure. Likely the scrapyard. It doesn't matter as long as I served my function."

Was this fact not true for the trees around them? Where did they go once they were done shading the ground? What of an individual leaf that falls to the ground finally done collecting the sun? Do the seeds squirrels plant in the ground yet never sprout go somewhere? Is an individual blade of grass worthy of an afterlife?

"I will try to find another way. Just let me run some numbers," Janus said.

11.

Ken woke up under a bright light shining down on him. Unable to see into the darkness around him, instead he looked to his left where Jo was tied to a chair straining against the rope wrapped around her and on his right Rufus was tied up, still unconscious. He tried to move his hands, but they were tied behind him around the chair he sat in.

"Dracula, are you okay?" Ken asked, using Jo's codename in case someone was listening in.

"I'm fine. How about you?"

"In one piece. Where are we?"

"I think the auditorium where Cowherd plans to perform his sacrifice. Probably wants us to chip in too," Jo said.

"Listen, whatever happens tonight, I want you to know I'm sorry I couldn't save your parents. I miss my sister. I really do."

"I don't blame you, Uncle Ken. It's on the Alpha Squadron. It was just a shit day."

"And I'm sorry I wasn't there as much as I should have been. I should have stepped up more. I just—I just only saw her when I looked at you. I only saw that day. But even if I was distant, know that I love you unconditionally."

"Love you too unconditionally, Uncle Ken, but don't go getting all sappy. I'm getting us out of here."

"Good evening, my suitors."

The lights shifted to reveal Cowherd standing right in front of them. They were on the stage in the auditorium. In the stands, hundreds of minions sat watching the four of them.

"You know, I admire this hero thing. I had some heroes in my family at a time. It's honest work. Although if anything I expected the Nexus Magistrate to chase after me. Can't say I was expecting this . . . gathering of eclectic faces."

Cowherd paced back and forth in front of them. He pulled out an amulet on a necklace from his pocket and dangled it in the air. The stage lights made the Soul Siphon sparkle as it swung through the air.

"I really don't want you to take this personally. I do believe in what you do. I really do . . . it's just I don't quite trust you all to get it right."

"Maybe I should call up your family and have them bring you in," Dracula said.

"I would call my son, but a little hard to do when he's dead."

"I'm sorry for your loss," Ken said.

"I'm sure you are. S-Day extracted a heavy toll from all sorts of people."

The color disappeared from Ken's face. His mouth dried up. Dracula looked over to see her uncle squirming at the sentence.

"Hey, my parents died too that day. Maybe we could do that whole found family thing. You know, two pieces of the puzzle," Dracula said. Ken looked at the ground. He dragged each breath of his out never managing to grab much air.

"It's not the fact that he died that haunts me. It's more how he died. Do you know that when I found him there was a stick jammed through his throat?" Cowherd asked. He pointed his second and third finger to his Adam's Apple. Dracula saw sweat bead on Ken's head. He began to mutter something to himself repeating it under his breath. "He was just left there propped up on the ground like some sort of demented scarecrow left behind to scare away any do-gooders who dared." Cowherd bent over so his head was at the same level as Ken's. Ken continued to mutter to himself.

"A little timid, are we? Imagine my surprise when my people confiscated your broom, Demon Duster. Did you know it is made of cedar wood? The exact same type of wood that was jammed into my son's throat!" Cowherd let his sentence echo through the room. He took a breath. "Probably just a coincidence, right? Life is funny like that. Although it does make me hate you just a little bit."

Ken still faced the ground yet to acknowledge Cowherd's speech. Dracula looked to Cowherd who was now standing up straight again. She looked past him to see Rufus stir in his chair.

"Oh, brother. I had this nightmare where a man dressed up in a Halloween costume forced me to listen to his soliloquy. He kept going and going because he loved to hear the sound of his own voice so much." Rufus lifted his head up and opened his eyes. "Would you look at that. It wasn't a nightmare at all."

"You jest but look at your coworker right here. He is just about going to sweat through that jumpsuit of his. In fact . . . No. No. I am beginning to question," Cowherd said. He reached his hand up into the darkness of his hood, presumably to rub his chin. "You are about old enough . . . Tell me. Where were you on S-Day?"

Ken looked up at Cowherd. He opened his mouth, but nothing came out. It had been hours since the poison had first entered his system but at this moment it felt more potent than ever before.

"You will TELL ME where you were!" Cowherd shouted. He smacked the back of his hand against Ken's face knocking his chair over to the side.

12.

Music played at the Transaction Tavern when Ken sat in their dining area across from Jo. Of course there was music. There's always music playing in there. Jo picked at the salad he bought her from the premade food section. An unwrapped turkey sandwich rested on the table in front of him. He refused to touch it with his bare hands. What was that song playing that day?

He watched Jo pick out the tomatoes from her salad until his eyes drifted past her. When he looked at his hands, he could just barely see the bloodstains still there. The soap in the bathrooms there could only do so much. In the background he heard the news playing on the TVs. The cashiers stood turned to it watching the reporter cover the state of Hope City. Their manager had stepped out from the back room and turned up the volume so they could all hear it.

"Aw . . . Jesus . . ." the white-haired manager said.

Ken's right hand wouldn't stop twitching. It was as if he was trying to grasp his broom. Perhaps he wished to feel the wood. He wished to feel steady. A cut on Jo's head had dried a deep black by this point. She looked up to see him staring past her.

"Uncle Ken, you haven't had any of your sandwich."

“I know.” Ken turned his head to look at the grocery store then looked back at her. “Just waiting for Aunt Carol before I eat.”

Jo survived by hiding in a mirror tucked in her mom’s purse. When he had managed to find Jo in the wreckage, she was holding the purse. Perhaps she was waiting to give it back to her mom. He grabbed her and got them as far away as he could. They now sat across the river somewhere around the Langsle area. He hoped this was far enough, but honestly there was no way to know if the carnage would stay in the city.

“I thought those were the good guys,” one of the cashiers said.

“Probably just some mind control thing or something,” another said.

The automatic sliding doors opened, and Carol ran through them. She turned to see Ken. He waved to her, and she smiled. Once she was close to the table, she kissed Ken on the head and gave Jo a hug before sitting next to her.

“Sweetie, how are you doing? Are you okay?” Carol asked.

“I’m okay. When are we going back for Mom and Dad though?” she asked.

“We . . . We will go back for them once everything settles down,” Ken said. He reached for his sandwich but instead just rested his hand on the table. Carol reached over and grabbed his hand, rubbing his palm. She opened his hand and saw the bloodstains. Ken pulled his hands back then looked away from her.

“Alright. I am going to go to the bathroom. Is that okay?” Jo asked. Carol nodded and she walked off.

“Is that theirs?” Carol asked. Ken’s eyes watered. He wiped the back of his wrist against his face while he nodded his head left and right.

“Do we know if they’re alive?” Carol asked.

“I saw the rubble. I—I don’t think so. I don’t know how many people are dead. We may never even get confirmation.”

“Does—Does she know?”

“I’m not sure. We haven’t really talked about it yet.”

“Do you want to talk about your hands?” she asked.

“I—I tried to clean them. I tried to. I kept scrubbing but it isn’t going away. The soap here isn’t good for anything.” Carol looked down at the uneaten sandwich.

“They look plenty clean to me. You did a good job with what they have here.”

“Carol—I . . . I . . . Oh, dear God. I killed someone out there. I had to. He was keeping me from getting to Jo. I really didn’t want to, but I had to. What if I’m just like those people on the TV? Should I—”

“Stop. Don’t talk like that.”

“But I’ve never done that before. What if you can’t look at me the same?”

“Am I looking at you any different right now?” Carol asked. He stared into her blue eyes. Her gaze was steady. Calm but present. “It’s—It’s okay, Ken. I don’t know what’s happening over there. It’s a warzone. I can’t begin to imagine what you had to go through to get to her.”

“But what if I didn’t have to kill him?” he asked.

“I trust you, Ken. If you felt you had to then I trust you did.”

“He was just a—” Ken trailed off, sniffled, then said, “He was just a kid. Couldn’t have been more than twenty something.” Ken looked down at the sandwich. The cold deli meat rested beneath a single leaf of lettuce. He could smell it.

“You were put in a tough position, and you took a risk for Jo. Your sister would thank you because Jo is here with us right now.”

Ken put his head in his hands. “What . . . What are we going to do?”

“First, I’m going to get you a napkin for the sandwich so you can eat. Then, we solve the next problem.”

13.

Ken's chair crashed into the floor. His head cracked off the wood. The room began to spin around him. His vision blurred. He kept blinking trying to make the image clear.

"Who do you think gave him that broom? Same stuff my scythe is made of! You really think your son died to a broom?" Dracula shouted. Cowherd turned to her. He stepped so he stood right in front of her. Two minions came up out of the shadows and held the chair steady. Cowherd reeled his arm back then rammed it upward smashing it against the bottom of Dracula's chin. Her chair rocked on the ground. Black blood sprayed into the air. Her head fell back down, and she spit a dark fluid out of her mouth.

"Do you think me a fool? You are no older than he was. I doubt you were even walking back when he died."

"Haven't you caught on? I'm a vampire, jackass. I age differently."

Beneath his hood, Cowherd's nose twitched. He swung his arm out knocking Dracula's face to the side. Her chair wobbled to the side before the minions pulled it back down. Cowherd jabbed his fist forward smashing her stomach. He waited for her to breathe in before he rammed his fist back into her chest. Dracula gasped for air. His vision cleared while minions pulled Ken's chair back up so he could watch her squirm in her chair.

"You know, I think you've jogged my memory a bit. What'd you say his name was again? Sparky? Spark Starter? Was a real prick.

Clearly the apple doesn't fall far from the tree," Rufus said. Cowherd flicked his wrist shaking the black fluid off it onto the ground. He approached Rufus.

"How do you know that name?" Cowherd asked.

"It . . . It was me. I did it. I killed him," Ken said.

"No. No, that's not what your friend says," Cowherd said.

"He was just too stuck up. Didn't know when to step down. Kid had no moral compass. Shouldn't have been playing with the big dogs," Rufus said.

"No! No, I did it. I was trying to save my family. I needed to get there, and he wouldn't let me go. I—"

"You know what they say. Play with fire, you're bound to get burned. My real question is what kind of parent lets their kid go off play hero? It is one thing stopping a robbery at the gas station, but walking into active domestic terrorism? Where were the parents at?" Rufus asked.

Cowherd nodded his head. The two minions holding Dracula's chair walked over to Rufus. They untied his arm bindings and stood him up so he was now face-to-face with Cowherd staring into his hood.

"I tried so hard to just go, but so much was happening. He was scared. I tried to talk to him, but he wouldn't listen!" Ken shouted.

“You know my last words to him?” Rufus asked. Cowherd stood silent. “I told him to say hello to my dog, Dixon, once he got up there.”

Cowherd ripped his arm forward and grasped Rufus’ throat. He lifted Rufus into the air, but Rufus did not squirm.

“Yeah—I didn’t handle his death too well either—I mean Dixon of course. I got over your son real quick,” Rufus choked out, the tips of his shoes barely touching the ground. Cowherd began to squeeze, his fist closing around Rufus’ aged skin. Still, he did not shake.

“Rufus! Stop it! Stop doing this! I did it! I killed your son! I did it with my broom. He broke it and I tripped him. He fell onto it and that was how he died!” Ken shouted. Rufus coughed as Cowherd’s hands closed around his esophagus. He looked down at Cowherd and with the light shining onto him at this angle he could just barely see the outline of Cowherd’s chin. Tears rolled down the edges of it.

Cowherd threw Rufus to the side. He tumbled across the floor. “I do not understand what you did to have people so willing to take the fall for you. What twisted lies you must have told them. What version of this sick tale did you tell them?” Cowherd asked. “Would they do this if they saw you on that day?”

“No,” Ken said.

“No, they wouldn’t,” Cowherd said. He turned around and grabbed his pendant out of his pocket. The Soul Siphon glittered under

the light. “Tonight, I correct the course. Get into positions! The ceremony is about to begin!”

14.

A spiraling portal appeared in the forest shining a bright green across the foliage. Marsh Man stared into it. The energy swirled in the air moving magical particles steadily toward the center of the portal. It had to have been no bigger than a kiddie pool and it mimicked the water of one if something were to be swimming in circles just beneath the surface.

"I haven't finished calculating possible entrance methods. We don't have to test this yet," Janus said. She held her palm out stressing her gears to keep the portal open.

~~"We must try."~~ Marsh Man was unsure of what he preferred. If this were to work, his friends would be saved. Unnecessary bloodshed could be prevented. If it didn't work, then just maybe there would still be hope for him.

Janus lifted her other palm up and a second portal formed at her side. She nodded at Marsh Man. He lifted his left arm slowly drifting his equivalent to a human's palm up to the energy. The brown sticks and dark green leaves grew brighter almost resembling what they looked like still attached to their trees as his hand closed in on the swirling energy.

The tips of his fingers touched the energy. It didn't burn. It didn't hurt. He was calm. He pushed himself into the portal. The energy from his body colliding with the portal glowed so bright he couldn't tell if his hand had gone through or was just pressed against it. It felt as if the world had coated his skin in warm wax and this portal was cold water cementing the cast.

Janus turned away from the growing light toward the second portal. Sticks dropped out from it toppling onto the ground. She shrunk her irises then looked at the first portal. She could see shreds of grass piled on the floor at Marsh Man's feet.

He kept pushing against the portal. The cold feeling of water spread across his body. The light became white. Marsh Man could only see the vague outline of his body but not where it began or where it ended.

Janus watched the mound of sticks increase in size. Shards of grass continued fluttering downward from the portal Marsh Man stood next to.

"Stop it! You proved yourself. You're not passing through the portal. It shouldn't be this hard!"

~~"No! I see that pile of sticks. I need to keep going until either all of me goes through or none!"~~ He pushed farther into the portal. All Janus saw was the yellow light of his eyes in the white supernova. Wind surged off the portal rustling the leaves disturbing the birds who flew off.

Janus dropped her hands. The portal closed and Marsh Man tumbled forward into the pile of grass. It coalesced into his form so that when he stood back up the left side of his body was all green missing the texture of his right. Janus summoned a portal beneath the sticks. Another appeared above Marsh Man dropping them onto him. The sticks sunk into his form slowly filling in his green half.

"I . . . I . . . What does that mean?"

"I'm sorry. I don't know."

Marsh Man collapsed to the ground his body losing its form, so it sunk toward the ground forming something of a marsh. Janus sat down next to him, sitting on her cloak so the plants did not clog her gears.

"All if not lost though. Your efforts have sparked a new plan."

15.

“Your mistakes are why we are here today! Do not fret. You are only human. Mistakes are expected. I am too, but soon I shall ascend beyond such pathetic things.” Cowherd raised the siphon into the air. Purple sparks danced off the amulet. “Begin the first phase. Once the first wave of souls has been absorbed and handled begin the second phase. This is what we have been waiting for! Move it people!”

Dozens of minions dashed around the opera house shifting between the rows ready to enact their play. Rufus crawled toward the side of the stage leaving a trail of blood behind him. Minions set Ken back up so he could see the magnitude of the operation going on around them.

“Look! Look how many people selfless people believe in this mission. They know that they alone don’t have what it takes to change the world. That they aren’t capable of making such decisions. If only you folks shared the same sentiment,” Cowherd said turning toward Ken.

“You’re just manipulating them. How many truly understand the sacrifice they are making tonight? How many have been shown the power they have as an individual?” Dracula asked.

“Hmm. You heroes are always so funny. Making decisions for everyone else and then telling us what to think. Feel free to speak up. By all means, if you can dissuade them with a speech then be my guest,” Cowherd said. He grabbed Rufus by his boot and dragged him back to the center of the stage. The minions got into place and the spotlights shined down on Cowherd.

“Let us begin! Join me—” Cowherd began to say. A stick bounced off his head. He ignored it and prepared to continue his sentence only to be stopped by an onslaught of sticks falling from the sky. He saw the lime green light reflecting off the floor and looked up to see a portal above them covering the entire ceiling.

“They are here! Act quickly!”

Once the sticks covered the entire floor the portal disappeared. One moment the ceiling was black. Then everything above them was green. Then all they could see above moon and the stars in the sky. Janus floated above them all having teleported the roof to the building elsewhere. All that could be seen from the ground was the black outline of her body and two green lights right beneath her hat.

“Join me, my servants! Give your souls to me!” Cowherd shouted. The minions up on the balconies chanted before collapsing. The minions on the ground watched the hundreds of servants above grow quiet, only for a small, glowing ball of purple energy to rise from each of them. They flew into the air coalescing in one stream that flowed into Cowherd.

Janus flicked her fingers. Dozens of small portals appeared around Dracula and Ken’s chair eating up the wood before disappearing leaving them all freely able to move. The sticks began to shift below them pushing the minions on the ground floor toward the wall as if they were in a tidal pool. Ken turned to see a mass of moss, leaves, vines, and roots sliding down the wall seeping into the wood giving it life.

Marsh Man appeared out of the ocean of sticks. He picked up Ken, Dracula, and Rufus before leaping to the opposite side of the concert hall now emptied with the minions still trying to push away from the walls. Waves of sticks covered their entire bodies drowning them in rotting wood. Janus landed next to him.

~~"Should we try and stop the souls?"~~ Marsh Man asked.

"It's no use. We can't interact with such mystical material. All we can do is wait."

16.

Dear Carol,

People tell me I should talk to myself in the same way I talk to others. Hell, I should just talk to myself in the same way my Younger, or my even Younger, version of myself would. I know the Young adult would tell me it is fine. There is still so much to live after all. I know the kid would tell me that I looked like a "good person".

What about the me right now? What is he saying? That's what bothers me. I just wish I could sometimes get away from him and spend some more time with one of those other versions of myself ... or spend the time with You. Love You.

Love,

kenneth

There was a tin lunchbox Ken owned as a kid. His mother gave it to him. Throughout elementary school his lunch was packed in it every single day. It was this metal box that had the Alpha Squadron painted onto it. This was a different roster than the one that tore down Hope City. They were still perfect in Ken's mind.

Ken couldn't remember the main hero's name, but they were posing on the front holding their thumb up. There was this phrase written in big, bubbly letters. "There's a hero in all of us!" Ken read that sentence every weekday for years when he went to eat his lunch. The phrase repeated ad nauseum until he automatically thought of it whenever he went to eat.

He gave that lunchbox to Jo when she entered elementary school. Somehow it was still in one piece after all those years with the paintings mostly legible. After S-Day, he had to buy her a new one, but he always kept that one under his bed. He just couldn't bring himself to throw it away. That lunchbox his mom gave him always remained there resting beneath his heart when he slept at night.

That lunchbox given to him by his mom was something funny. When Ken tried to remember what his mother was like, all he could remember was how loud she yelled. Her scoldings blended into one mix, the individual memories indistinguishable.

Her voice rattled the plates on the wall. The tin would shake against the wallpaper creating just the slightest sound that only he ever heard. His dogs didn't like it either. They'd run away once she began one of her tirades. They'd run as far away as they could into the house

cowering in his room unable to understand this other side of their watchful protector.

She'd disappear for hours after ripping into each person in the house, finding just one miniscule thing they had miscalculated to latch onto and tear into a conflict. The house was so quiet on those days. No one had anything to say. There was nothing to be done. They knew that the things she said weren't entirely untrue yet not quite true. Something became hollowed out within them.

He couldn't remember how she was on Christmas morning, but only her yelling at his dad when they drove around the neighborhood looking at lights the night before. He knew she had prepared activities for his friends when they came over but all he could truly recall was her rabid words leading up to their arrival. There was no peaceful moment his sister, his mom, and him shared in his memory.

These memories were not by choice. He tried to hold onto the good things. He knew she was thoughtful and that she cared about him. They smiled together. They laughed together. But here he was now.

This entity was impossible to separate from himself. Her blood was his. Her mind was his. He knew this blood was not bad, rotting at the tree, but what had caused that dark part of the woman who gave him that lunchbox? Was there some spirit attached to her, hunched on her shoulder, whispering the wrong things? How else could such a person exist? Something was wrong, but he never knew what.

What if the blood was bad? What if that blood flowed through his veins? What if this confusing mind was somewhere deep within himself? Perhaps that spirit had leapt from her anchoring itself into him? How much of him was her? He would never know.

What would she think of him now? Better yet, what would the him of then see? Her or himself?

17.

Cowherd collapsed to the ground energy surging across his body. Over a hundred souls slipped through his veins reaching every inch of his body. Purple energy crackled across his skin and the room began to smell of burnt hair. He threw off his hood and screamed out. Marsh Man helped Dracula, Ken, and Rufus get to their feet while they witnessed this rebirth helpless to stop it. Rufus attempted to shake off the pain and began to stretch in preparation for the impending battle.

Cowherd's body convulsed and the purple light grew brighter. Ken had to cover his eyes to block out the blinding light, but he could see the shadow of Cowherd mold. A thick tail appeared behind him. The force of it slamming against the ground shook the floor. His legs morphed to resemble that of a cow with hooves bursting through his shoes. Miraculously, the hood made of cow skin grew with his body as it changed shape. When the light finally faded, he was still on the ground. It was hard to tell his height from their position, but Ken assumed he had to be at least eight feet tall.

"What the hell happened to him?" Dracula asked. She held her scythe tightly in her hands black blood dried underneath her lips at the corners of her mouth.

"That tail . . . it's just like . . ." Rufus said to himself.

"His body can't handle the energy. It's molding around his ideals," Ken said. Cowherd almost looked like the demons the Nexus Magistrate fought. "I don't think he'll be able to sustain the form."

"YOU THINK SO LOW OF ME. I HAVE GONE SO, SO MANY YEARS PREPARING FOR THIS. THESE SOULS ARE MINE. NOW, THEIR MEANINGLESS LIVES HAVE A PURPOSE." Cowherd stood up, his eyes glowing purple under the hood. "THEY WILL SERVE AS THE CATALYST TO THE NEW WORLD THAT I—"

A gunshot echoed through the room and a bullet clattered to the ground at Cowherd's hooves. Rufus slammed the bolt on his rifle and fired another shot that cracked off Cowherd's chest simply leaving a hole in his hood.

"I don't really give a damn." He continued his approach, firing off five more bullets before his gun ran empty. Marsh Man ran out from behind them clenching his fist, his body growing larger in size.

"Just hold him off until he burns out. We can hold this line!" Ken shouted. Marsh Man was now over nine feet tall, and he slammed his fist upward into Cowherd. His fist shattered in an explosion of flora spraying green grass and rotting leaves into the air. Just as the grass settled from the air and Marsh Man disappeared, Cowherd saw the green outline of a circle in front of him. A portal appeared and a grey car flew through it slamming against him.

Cowherd caught the car and threw it at Dracula who was beginning her approach toward him. She jumped into the air and sliced the car in half with her scythe before rolling against the ground.

“Cover Rufus!” she shouted. Dracula slammed her scythe against the ground and flew upward. She grabbed a grenade filled with shards of mirrors and pulled the trigger before throwing it upward.

It flew up toward the ceiling. There was a moment of silence, then an explosion sent shrapnel of mirror shards spraying outward. Ken swiped his broom against the ground kicking up a wind wall in front of Rufus and him. Janus created a portal in front of her sending the shrapnel that was directed at her back toward Cowherd. Marsh Man embraced the shards and let them mold with his form. The sticks at the wall blocked the remaining shrapnel from cutting into the minions who were still pushed against the wall by them.

Dracula’s eyes flickered red before she disappeared in a black smoke cloud that dashed into a mirror. As the mirror shards fell to the ground, she bounced between them crashing against Cowherd in a blur of black smoke.

Once the mirror shards hit the floor she flew out of a piece and slid to a stop next to Ken. She hunched over to catch her breath. The sticks covered in mirror shards at the side walls slipped across the ground melding into Marsh Man’s body increasing his size.

With the tidal wave of sticks now gone, the minions at the sides collapsed to the ground tired from the sticks’ scorn but some managed to stand back up and cheered out watching the fight in front of them. They pumped their fists in the air shouting out Cowherd’s name. It had been hard to see if she had hurt Cowherd through the smoke, but when it faded, they could see that Cowherd still stood standing. Most of his

cloak had been torn off except for the hood which sat over his head unchanged.

“How long until he pulls in the rest of their souls?” Dracula asked.

“Not sure,” Ken said.

“Can you stop him from doing that?” Dracula asked.

“Give me a bit.”

“You’ll figure it out,” Rufus said. “I’ll chew on it too.”

“IF YOUR HOPE IS TO WEAR ME DOWN THEN I DO NOT FEEL IT WAS WISE TO LEAD WITH YOUR BEST,” Cowherd said.

“Don’t you worry. I’m full of surprises!” Rufus said. He threw a bear trap out. It spiraled through the air toward Cowherd. It crashed against Cowherd and the trap triggered but instead of snapping shut it broke into two pieces.

“YOUR TOYS MEAN NOTHING TO ME NOW.”

“Just wanted to make sure it would be fair if I used this,” Rufus said. Ken didn’t know when, but at some point, Rufus had slid two black gloves over his hand. He grabbed two fisticuffs out of his pocket and slid the metal over the cloth. A vial slipped out of Rufus’ sleeves, and he popped it open. A mixture of oil and holy water poured over his fists.

As Rufus lathered the solution over his hands Marsh Man charged forward once more; his gargantuan form rocking the room. Cowherd prepared to block a punch, but Marsh Man ran straight up to him and into him. Ken heard glass shatter followed by the sight of grass and wood bursting into the air. Cowherd stood with dozens of glass shards spread across his body. Once the grass fell to the ground it slowly began to gather in a puddle of mush picking up sticks while sliding across the ground.

“Better not have been lying about these gloves.” Rufus cracked the fisticuffs off each other. Sparks flew into the air and flames burst around his fists. Cowherd tensed his body, and the glass shards dislodged themselves from his skin. “Follow my lead, Kid,” Rufus said to Dracula.

“Give me a lift!” Rufus shouted. Ken nodded, swept his broom, and before Cowherd could fully recover from Marsh Man’s attack Rufus spiraled through the air, his fist outstretched. His fist collided with Cowherd’s face and Cowherd toppled over. Rufus tumbled to the ground next to him. Dracula ran toward the stage dragging the blade of her scythe across the ground spewing sparks into the air.

This gathering of supernatural heroes battled Cowherd five against one. Ken watched Rufus and Dracula spin around Cowherd who swatted at them. Janus continued to summon various hazards that rained down on Cowherd, never quite phasing him. Green mush slid across the ground moving between the seats. All Ken had was his broom.

He turned toward the audience. Ken pointed to the stands above. "Look at this! This is what will happen to you if you don't snap out of it right now!" The audience grew quiet. "What a waste of life! Their souls aren't coming back. None of them are!" He could hear the fight carrying on behind him.

"Look at your leader! Look what you will become a part of. Your souls are next, but we can save them, but you need to want to. I need you to want your souls. Fight for that part of yourself! Don't let him take it!"

"DON'T LISTEN TO HIM! MAINTAIN YOUR POSITIONS. SIDE WITH STRENGTH! YOU HAVE THE CHANCE TO MEAN SOMETHING TODAY!" Cowherd shouted. He swatted Dracula to the side, and she dragged the scythe against the ground to catch herself. Rufus rolled to avoid a punch before swinging an uppercut that only managed to hit Cowherd's chest. Minions began to murmur to each other. Cowherd kicked a hoof out and it collided with Rufus' chest sending him tumbling backward.

"No! You do mean something. You mean something every day. And it doesn't matter if you're here now. I don't care how you got here because one bad accident doesn't define you! Don't let him define you! You are every single action you take, not just one day!" The murmuring grew louder into more of a grumble.

Dracula swung her scythe downward and Cowherd blocked it. He swept Dracula off her feet then pinned her to the ground with one of his hooves. She screamed out as he pushed it deeper into her. Rufus

lay sprawled out on the ground in front of the wall. Marsh Man had barely formed even a pile of leaves.

“Get out of there now, Dracula! I’m dropping a car again!”

“Work with me here! Fight to keep your soul!” Ken turned to see Dracula grab a shard of mirror. She disappeared into it. A green portal appeared above Cowherd and a school bus dropped through it.

“I HAVE HAD ENOUGH OF YOUR RAMBLING!”

Cowherd punched the school bus sending it rolling across the ground toward Ken. It caught a few unlucky minions in its path toward him. He swept his broom against the ground, but the bus was moving with such force that it rolled through the gust and crashed into Ken. There was pain. A sharp pain. Then darkness.

18.

Ken swept the floors of the elementary school brushing a pile of dust across the tiles picking up bits of wrappers and crumbs. He moved down the first-grade hallway and looked through the window to the door of Classroom 105. Carol stood in front of a chalkboard drawing out a representation of the water cycle. Ken knocked on the window with his knuckle. She kept drawing but turned to look toward him and flashed a brief smile before looking back at the board. Ken smiled and walked away listening to the kids in the room shout out his favorite things.

“Oooooohhhh. Was that the janitor?”

“You like him!!!”

“Is he going to come in to say hi?”

“Was that your husband, the cleaning man?”

He kept moving down the hallways sweeping the pile of dust farther and farther. Ken stared at the various paintings hung up on the wall from a recent project. On each paper a combination of squares and rectangles had been glued together to form some sort of a Measurement Man. Each square represented a cup, pint, quart, or gallon. The smallest ones represented cups and were his fingers.

His broom got caught on something and he looked down to see his bristles dipping into a pool of blood. The blood wasn't fresh. Congealed globules stuck between his broom's hairs. He continued to push the pile of dust down the hallway in the direction the blood originated from just rolling it through the fluid. It seemed to have

come from Room 108. Ken made his way up to the room and looked through the window in the door.

Spark Starter laid slumped over a wooden spike on the ground with the point of it sticking through the bottom of his chin and up through his mouth. Instead of the tiled floor to the school, beneath him was the rubble of a city. His body still shook erratically. They were sudden shakes from twitches in his arms. The final sputters of his brain. Ken could hear him trying to let loose a cough, but he could only get out a grumble. His eyelids opened and his eyes looked toward Ken who flipped away from the door and leaned up against the wall next to a Measurement Man.

A chorus of cries echoed out from Room 109 and Ken walked toward the door dragging his broom through the ground behind him. The pile he had swept up remained in front of Room 108. He knew what he would see. That laugh. That many laughing. It was uncanny. There was only one time he had heard this horrific sound before.

He saw zombies hunched over a backyard lawn in a circle digging their hands into the grass tearing shreds of it up into the air. He watched their mix of wailing and laughing. The corpses rolled over onto their backs and began to kick their feet into the air. Their cackling was muffled through the door but now that they had flipped over Ken could see that not all the zombies were adults. He averted his eyes and continued down the hallway.

The blood continued to clot in between the bristles of his broom until it grew too cumbersome to drag behind him. Headlights

shined out of Room 114's window illuminating the hallway in front of him. The yellow lights washed out the white florescent tubes above him behind plastic panels. Ken walked up to the room and used his hand to cover his eyes and block out some of the light.

It was still far too bright to make out anything definitive, but he could see the outline of a man. He was on his knees. A large cross towered above the man. Something was attached to it. Ken stared longer into the light trying to see what was hanging from the wood, but his eyes began to burn, and he turned away from the room.

So many doors laid in front of him, blood coating the floor. He just didn't know why they were always there. Of everything that could possibly follow him, why these rooms? What kind of person was he to have witnessed such things, even take part in some? What kind of person sees these rooms in their hallway? Did he put these rooms there? Was it his fault they stuck around?

Ken turned around. He walked back toward Room 105. Once he passed Room 108 and crossed back over to bare tile, his boots left tracks of red behind him. When he got back to Room 105 the window was dimmed. He tried the door, but it was locked. Ken put his back up against the wall and he slid down to the ground. He looked up to see various Measurement Men, of varying quality, attached to the wall in front of him. Some were missing a couple of squares. Perhaps the glue the kids used hadn't held. He put his head into his hands.

"It should've been me first. It shouldn't have been you.

“Carol, please . . . I need someone here to tell me I’m a good person. Someone who truly knows me. Someone who knows everything I’ve done and every horrible thing I think about. I need someone who knows me, all of me, to say I’m good.

“It’s been so long since you’ve told me that. Maybe you wouldn’t still agree with what you said seeing me now? Maybe you never truly knew me well enough to know I was good. How could you have? You can’t completely know me.

“God . . . Oh, God . . . Someone . . . just please tell me.”

Ken slid his hands up his face, so his palms covered his eyes, and his fingers were grasping his silver hair. He could feel his scalp and the loose skin dragging over his skull as he pushed against it. The silence was broken by the sound of ripping tape.

He looked up to see Carol sticking a leg back on to a Measurement Man with scotch tape. She slid her finger over the tape to remove any creases then stepped back from the wall to look at the complete man again.

“They’re always so amazed by how much fits in a gallon. Doesn’t look like much when it’s in your fridge, but we’re talking four quarts, eight pints, or sixteen cups. I like to have them guess how many teaspoons are in just one gallon. You know what it is?” Carol asked. Ken remained quiet staring up at her, his mouth open.

“Seven hundred sixty-eight. There’s a lot to Measurement Man if you want to look intricately at him. Not even sure where that many

squares would go. Maybe his hair? There just isn't much point in making the kids cut up that many pieces. I'd rather just focus on the bigger picture . . . like the pints and quarts." Carol reached behind her back and grabbed Ken's broom out of thin air. She held it out to him. Ken stood up and grabbed the broom. They held it staring at each other.

He looked into her eyes, but they weren't really her eyes. No, the real things were much brighter, much more intricate. There were no waves in the irises he was looking at now. He hadn't actually seen her eyes in years. He missed them, but this was still nice.

"I love you," he said. The world began to fade to black around them. An echoing in the distance grew louder and louder. It all disappeared until it was just the two of them hands on top of each other over the broom. The voices in the distance grew louder and louder.

"Get this off—"

"Someone help me out here!"

"Lift on three."

"We just got to lift this end up to get him out!"

Carol began to fade, her hands disappearing to leave Ken holding the broom alone. Ken grabbed the broom and held it at his side.

"Hurry it up! They're not going to last long."

“I’m trying!”

“Try harder! Give it all you got!”

Then, a different voice spoke out.

A special one.

“I love you too.”

19.

Ken opened his eyes to find dozens of Cowherd's minions around him. They dragged him away from the bus then sat him down on the ground. His vision began to clear, and he saw Dracula spinning around Cowherd on the stage. Rufus, Janus, and Marsh Man laid sprawled out unconscious. Dracula flipped over Cowherd and dug her scythe into his back ripping it downward. She dragged it down his back and unhooked herself to roll away before he could hit her.

One of the minions clapped in Ken's face then said, "Hey, let's go. Get up. You said you knew how to keep us from dying tonight. Well, we don't want to die." The minion grabbed Ken's hand and pulled him up, so he was standing. Another brought his broom to him. The minions looked toward him. They were all hidden behind the bus, but through the broken windows Ken could see the fight on the stage.

"Alright. Alright . . . I have an idea. I can save you all.

"This will not be easy. Once he activates the Soul Siphon again it will do everything it can to make you let go of your soul. Hold strong to your conviction! Remember what you've fought for. Remember those you care about. Remember what you respect in another. Look past your mistakes, those thoughts that sneak up on you, and count on yourself. Only you can save your soul," Ken said.

The minions muttered to each other.

"Well, I'm screwed then," one of them said.

"No! No, you are not. Just fight as hard as you can and I will fight harder," Ken said. He looked back through the bus to see Dracula

run up to Cowherd. He slammed his hoof into the ground spewing up chunks of concrete. Dracula switched her form to smoke and slipped through the shrapnel. She rose up into the air and turned back into her human form. While she fell, she swung her scythe downward.

Before her blade met Cowherd, he ripped his arm forward and grabbed her by the neck. She choked out something, but Ken couldn't hear what. Her legs swung wildly in the air as she smacked her fists against his arm.

"ENOUGH!" Cowherd swung his arm forward. Dracula went flying through the wall off into the distance. **"IT IS READY. COME TO ME, MY MINIONS!"** He snapped his fingers, and the bus slid over revealing Ken and the minions behind it. **"EXCELLENT WORK HOLDING HIM STILL."** Cowherd grabbed the amulet hanging around his neck and a purple glow grew brighter and brighter slipping between his fingers.

One by one the minions collapsed to their knees. They hunched over onto the ground grasping at the floor with their fingers. Their bodies shivered viciously. Ken could feel a searing in his chest grow stronger as if glass was trying to find its way out of his heart. His eyes began to water, but through it he saw the room grow brighter. Slowly, orbs of light began to rise into the air. The air around them began to flow upward kicking up dust and shreds of grass laid across the ground.

First the unconscious. Rufus' soul rose up and began to drift toward Cowherd. It was a bright orange. Next, an orb rose out of

Janus; a shining silver radiated from it. Steadily, screams rose out from the minions. Their bodies writhed on the ground; a purple light growing brighter in their chest. They grasped at their hearts, but the light shined unchanged. The wind grew stronger, blowing through Ken's hair.

"RELEASE THEM TO ME! GIVE ME YOUR POWER!"

Ken fell over. On the ground, he looked to his right. Spark Starter's empty suit crackled on the ground. The faceplate was missing, and it had an enormous hole in its chest. Ken blinked and it was gone. He looked to his left. In between the minions writhing on the ground, he could swear he saw Zombie rolling on the floor giggling. His high-pitched laughing rang through the screams.

The purple aura on each minion's chest grew more vibrant by the second. Ken had mere moments to act. He jammed his broom into the ground and pushed against it to slowly pull himself back up. The glass in his chest was now bouncing off the walls. It wanted to be let out. It wasn't meant to be there. All he had to do was let it go.

Ken looked down to his chest and noticed it was glowing a calm cyan. Whoever was looking after Carol up above, the only thing Ken hoped from Them, was that They could see who he truly was. If anyone would be able to, They would know how to see what made a person.

That mix of emotion and values. What would it look like to Them? A mess of clay warm from the touch of a hand? A house built

brick-by-brick? What did this glowing orb look like to Them? What did it reveal? Around him, purple orbs rose up into the air.

Please. See my soul and tell me it is good. Tell me I am something worthy of those that came before me.

The cyan light coated the floor in front of Ken. He could see it slowly slipping through his chest. That conviction Ken had spoken of; he was unsure if even he possessed it. It felt like the glass was digging its way through his rib cage. He could have just spit out, but his mouth remained clenched. It was forcing its way through him. The cyan orb formed in the air right in front of Ken.

He stared at it floating there. He watched it slowly rise into the air ready to join the waves of purple.

Off in the distance a green light coated the room. Ken looked to see an emerald orb floating above a pile of grass and dead twigs. It shined brighter than the other orbs and had to have been about twice the size of any of the others. Spots of grey flickered across it affecting the color but not changing how brightly it shined.

Ken looked toward the cyan orb still within reach. It floated there. It taunted him.

“Give . . . me . . . my soul back!” Ken ripped his arm forward and grabbed the cyan orb floating above him. He grasped it within his hands. The orb appeared smooth yet when he touched it, he felt as if shards of glass were rolling across his skin. Ken gripped his soul and slammed his fist into his chest.

The cyan light disappeared.

Ken grabbed his broom. Now, the aura of cyan burned brighter than ever on the bristles. He looked up to the waves of purple orbs spiraling toward Cowherd slowly siphoning into his body. He had grown at least three feet since before he started this process. Ken swept his broom against the ground sending a gust of energy across the room disrupting the flow of souls. He swung his broom around using it to swirl the purple orbs around them. He kept sweeping the ground. With each swipe the souls bounced through the air as if they were dust particles caught by his bristles.

Instead of a spiral, the souls now floated above them in erratic patterns resembling stars in the sky rather than a whirlpool directed toward Cowherd.

"DO NOT KEEP THE SOULS EXPOSED FOR TOO LONG! YOU KNOW WHAT THAT WILL DO!" Cowherd shouted. He took one hand off the amulet and pointed his open palm at Ken. A burst of purple energy flew out. Ken brushed the ground, and a gust of wind sent the energy upward. It exploded above them showering purple particles and further spreading out the souls.

"Then stop! I can keep them away, but you need to let me help! It's not too late."

"IT'S BEEN TOO LATE SINCE THAT FATEFUL DAY." Cowherd burst forward on all fours crushing the ground with his hooves. Instantly, he appeared in front of Ken and grabbed him.

Cowherd was now so big that his hand wrapped around Ken's entire body. When he landed, he slammed Ken into the ground dragging him across it knocking seats to the side. Once they came to a stop Ken laid dug into the floor with Cowherd pinning him down. Ken looked up to see the sparkling purple orbs slowly fall back down. It was beautiful.

Ken opened his hand, and his broom began to fly to him, but Cowherd grabbed the stick with his free hand before Ken could get it. He smacked the broom against the ground cracking it in half. With the head of the broom cracked off he now held a sharpened wooden rod.

"WAS IT LIKE THIS? WAS THIS HOW YOU STABBED HIM?" Cowherd shouted. He spun the broom in his hand as if it was a toothpick.

Ken's head rang. He tried to focus his eyes to see the souls in the air, but it was too blurry to make out anything. After swallowing blood that had pooled in his mouth, Ken said, "I . . . did what I had to do. Your son had left me no choice. I'm so . . . so sorry."

"NO! NOT GOOD ENOUGH!" Cowherd lifted Ken into the air and slammed him back into the ground. Shards of the floor dug into Ken's back. Blood stained his white jumpsuit turning it a pink hue. **"NO! NO! YOU DON'T GET TO JUST SAY THAT!"**

Standing above Ken, Cowherd saw that this monster he despised was just a man. The purple souls fell around them steadily returning to their bodies. He looked down to his arms and saw their gargantuan form, his veins pulsating with purple energy.

“I’ve never forgiven myself. I hate myself for it. I’m sorry. I’m truly sorry . . .” Ken said. His vision began to fade, and the room became black. Cowherd dropped Ken’s broom, the wood clattering against the floor. He stepped back and watched Ken slowly breathe in and out. He was just an old man beaten and bloody.

It wasn’t supposed to be this way. His son’s killer should have been a monster, not a man who works a job. It was supposed to be a supervillain not a hero. It should have been a detached machine unphased by their bloody crimes willing to do it again.

How many sons and daughters sat in the balconies above them their souls now consumed by him? The world needed to be fixed. He was not wrong. It failed his son. It failed him, but simply the fact the second wave of souls had not immediately transferred to him demonstrated the misguided philosophy behind Cowherd’s convictions.

Ken mustered all his strength for one last stand. It was not over quite yet. He could feel it. Carol was watching. Jo was here. Spark Starter’s dad stood silent above him. He still heard Zombie’s laugh just faintly in the distance never truly leaving him. For these people, Ken made one last effort.

Once he had gathered enough energy, Ken did not stand. In fact, he did not even open his eyes. Instead, he spoke.

“I’m sorry . . . I couldn’t save you either.” Ken coughed up blood before returning to an unconscious state.

Cowherd sat down, the ground shaking beneath him from his weight. They say your body becomes just a little lighter once you pass. Perhaps that weight is your soul finally departing. Cowherd felt the weight of each soul bare down on his chest. Their desires, beliefs, and hopes burdened his body.

Cowherd looked to the sky. They were coming for him. The souls had been out for too long and he was exactly what they were looking for. Speckled between the stars, colored dots in the distance grew larger. The ghouls would take these souls from him.

“I forgive you.” Cowherd closed his eyes and waited for the spirits to feast on him. All he hoped for was that the pain would be brief, and his son would be waiting for him after.

20.

Dear Carol,

There are moments where I see me for who I want to be. I'm not sure how I would describe the feeling. Maybe it feels like the sunlight streaking through the clouds coating the sky in a warm hue. Or maybe it feels like for just a bit there is weight taken off my chest. For a while I can actually take deep breaths when I lay down.

Those moments came around a lot more with You here, but there are still people around. I've got Rufus and I got Jo which still counts for a lot. I wish it could just go away. Although does anything truly go away entirely? I certainly hope not.

Maybe I'm just some stubborn old man. Too stubborn to go easy on myself. Too stubborn to retread my past. Too stubborn to listen to others. Too stubborn to stop writing You letters...

I love You, Carol. I really do. I miss You and I love You all at the same time. I look forward to when we meet again, but I will not waste the time I have left here.

Love,

Kenneth

White boots, coated grey, crashed against the road. He ran through the street. The sky appeared empty with the smoke covering the clouds. Fragments of buildings were all that remained to his left and right. His lungs burned but he ran harder continuing to breathe in the smoke.

The fight had moved past this area. All that remained were the scraps of the city just low enough to the ground or just far enough off to the side to avoid destruction. He saw people fade in and out of the smoke around him. Countless voices called out searching for their family and friends. That was the only sound over the crackling charcoaled remains of the city.

“Jo!” Ken shouted. He overexerted himself on the scream and when he gasped for the air, he mostly got smoke. Ken coughed still running toward where she was supposed to be.

“JO! Where are you?” Ken avoided looking at the ground, only watching just enough to make sure he didn’t trip. He knew horrors hid in the smoke.

“JO!” Ken shouted again.

“Uncle Ken? Is that you?” he heard off in the distance.

“Jo! Stay right there!” Ken shouted. He picked up his pace now sprinting forward. Her outline appeared in the smoke. Ken’s hand lit up cyan blue and he swung his open hand forward pushing the smoke backward with a gust of air revealing Jo standing in front of a toppled building. Ashes had settled in her hair.

Ken ran forward and grabbed Jo, picking her up in the air as his arms wrapped around her. He grasped the back of her head when he pulled her close.

“Oh my God! Thank God you are okay. I’m here to get you out of here.”

“Mom and Dad told me you could come.”

“They were right. I’m here now. Where are . . . they?”

Ken set Jo down. He looked to the remains of the building around them. They stood in a sphere of clear air surrounded by smoke. Ash fell down above them as if they were a part of some sick twisted joke for a snow globe.

“Mom . . . Dad . . . They were . . .” Jo said.

“It’s okay. I know. I will look for them later. Just right now you are safe. That’s what matters most. We’re going to get out of here.” Ken reached out his hand and Jo grabbed it.

Together, they made their way out of S-Day.

And yet, the living prevail.